Scriptural Answers to:

Common Questions About the Grace Message

By
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COMMON QUESTIONS ABOUT THE GRACE MESSAGE

by Pastor Joel Finck

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FOREWORD

One of the joys of sharing the Grace message with people is to see that little imaginary light bulb go on when it finally clicks in their mind. Sometimes it takes a while for that light bulb to click. For this writer, it took about four months of being confronted with the Grace message and going back to the Scriptures and searching it out before it finally came together. But usually before everything falls into place, there are many questions which must first be answered. Sometimes this is due to a simple lack of Bible knowledge. Let's face it, when we first come to the Scriptures and especially the "Word rightly divided", many times we just don't know many things about the Bible. Perhaps we have not read it, or studied it as much as we should have. But more often than not, many of the questions arise because we've all been taught things that simply aren't true. Then when confronted with the truth, our mind immediately begins to question it, because it's different than what we've heard before or what we've been taught before. This is why we sometimes speak of having to unlearn some of the misconceptions that we've been taught before we can turn around and really learn the truth. As one preacher put it, "It's better to know nothing than to know what ain't so."

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The first thing that often strikes a newcomer to the Grace message, is that it sounds somewhat different than anything they have heard before. We believe this is because many churches simply neglect an in-depth study of the Word of God. We do not claim that the Grace message is anything new, only that it was not understood by many people for a long period of time. Our desire is to go back to the Scriptures to search these things out. This is why we often begin our messages by saying, "Don't take our word for anything we say. You are responsible before God to go to the Word of God and to see whether these things be so." If you do find that the indeed the Scripture does teach it, then believe it!

Even though the Grace message is unique in many respects, it actually agrees with most Christian churches in the major doctrines of the faith. We believe in the inspiration of Scriptures (II Timothy 3:15,16). Tragically, there are many denominations that have actually abandoned this very fundamental truth. We believe that God is a triune God - God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit. We believe in the deity of the Lord Jesus Christ: He is true God and true man in one person. We believe in the virgin birth of Christ, that He was conceived of the Holy Spirit, that He lived a sinless life, that He died for our sins, and that His death is sufficient for our salvation. There is absolutely nothing we can add

to it, indeed we must not add anything to what Christ accomplished through His death, burial and resurrection. We believe in the personality of the Holy Spirit. He is not merely a force out there, but is a personal God. We could go on and on, but we trust you get the point: we do hold to the basic, fundamental doctrines of the Word of God.

So how, then, is the Grace message unique? It is primarily in how we understand God's dealings with mankind through the ages. Most importantly, we believe that God revealed his message to us today through the Apostle of the Gentiles - Paul. This is usually when the questions begin. Here are some of the most common questions we have heard when sharing the Grace message.

1) Aren't you making too much of the Apostle Paul?

Of course any true Christian church will acknowledge that Paul was an Apostle. At least, they should. This is very clear in the Scriptures. But just where does Paul fit in? We believe that Paul was given a unique ministry and a unique message to us for today - the Body of Christ, the Church which is His Body.

Romans 11:13 says, **"For I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles, *I magnify mine office*."** Paul is often accused, even by some theologians, of being proud and arrogant. We have heard preachers say, "Oh, that Paul, he had an 'I' problem. He was always saying 'I, I, I this, I that'."
Why is it that Paul is always talking about himself? Was it because he wanted to exalt his own person or lift himself up before the people? No, of course not. We

need to remember that Paul wrote by inspiration. The Holy Spirit instructed him what to write. It was not just Paul of his own accord who suddenly decided to say, **"I speak to you Gentiles, I am the apostle to the Gentiles, I magnify mine office."** It was the Holy Spirit inspiring him to say this. And likewise, it is not just we who believe the Grace message who say Paul's office needs to be lifted up and magnified so we can see it. We didn't come up with that idea. It's right here in the Bible. See for yourself. ***"I magnify mine office"*** (Romans 11:13).

Regarding Paul's own person, he was actually a very humble man. In fact, he wrote **"Unto me who is *less than the least of all saints* is this grace given"** (Ephesians 3:8). Does this sound like a man who is exalting himself? In I Timothy 1:15, Paul calls himself **"*the chief of sinners*."** Does this sound like a man who is haughty, proud and lifted up? Of course not. In fact, it's interesting to note that Paul's very name means "small" or "little". Indeed, Paul in his own person, did not exalt himself, at least not after he was saved. Whenever he said "I" or "me", he was talking about what the Lord had done through him. **"By the Grace of God,"** Paul says, **"I am what I am"** (I Corinthians 15:10). These are the words of a very humble man.

Regarding his unique apostleship and message, Paul was very bold, forthright and outspoken. He did not mince any words, nor did he pull any punches. Let us look at several statements that Paul makes in emphasizing his own ministry and message.

Romans 2:16 says, **"In the day when God shall judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to *my***

***gospel*.**" Likewise, in Romans 16:25 we read, **"Now to him that is of power to stablish you according to *my gospel*."** Is Paul simply being proud when he says "my gospel"? No, God committed this message uniquely to Paul. He was the only one who could say of a message, "It's given to me for you. It's mine." The twelve apostles were also given a message. They were given the gospel of the Kingdom, yet it was given to all twelve. None of them could say "It's my gospel", because it was given to many. But Paul alone received the Gospel of the Grace of God and then he passed it on to others.

Notice in these texts that Paul refers to himself, not to magnify himself, but rather, to punctuate the importance of his apostolic ministry. **"For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; who will have all men to be saved, and come unto the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; who gave himself a ransom for all, to be testified in due time, whereunto *I am ordained a preacher, and an apostle*. (I speak the truth in Christ, and lie not.) a teacher of the Gentiles in faith and verity"** (I Timothy 3:2). Similarly in Galatians, the Apostle Paul refers to himself in Chapter 5 verse 2, **"Behold, *I Paul* say unto you, that if ye be circumcised, Christ shall profit you nothing."** Ephesians 3:1 says, *"***For this cause *I Paul*, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles."** Colossians 1:23 reads, **"If ye continue in the faith grounded and settled, and be not moved away from the hope of the gospel, which ye have heard, and which was preached to every creature which is under heaven; whereof *I Paul* am made a minister."**

This unique message had never been given before and it needed to be emphasized. Why must we emphasize the unique ministry of Paul? If we don't, who will? Paul himself magnified his office by the inspiration of the Holy Spirit. We, too, should magnify the God-given ministry and message which holds the answer to the theological confusion of our day.

2) Aren't you following a man instead of the Lord?

When we speak of Paul being the Apostle to the Gentiles, are we guilty of following a man? Let us see what the Scriptures say. Many times people will object to saying we should follow Paul as our Apostle, by pointing to Paul's own words in I Corinthians 1:12, **"Now this I say, that every one of you saith, I am of Paul; and I am of Apollos; and I am of Cephas; and I of Christ. Is Christ divided? Was Paul crucified for you? or were ye baptized in the name of Paul?"** Likewise, I Corinthians 3:3 says, **"For ye are yet carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men? For while one saith, I am of Paul; and another, I am of Apollos; are ye not carnal?"** There are some who would point to these verses and say, "Here it says that if you follow after Apollos or after Paul that you are just being carnal. That is a fleshly thing to do." The word "carnal" is the key to this context. Paul is pointing out that the Corinthians were following people after the flesh, and that is wrong. If we were to say "Let's follow Paul because he was a pretty smart guy", that would be wrong. Or if we said "Let's follow Paul because he seemed to gather a pretty good following in his day," that, too, would be the wrong reason. If we just liked the way Paul wrote or

liked his personality better than some other apostle, we would be guilty of following a man. This is what Paul is addressing here. I Corinthians 1 and 3 say it is wrong to follow a personality. But after he tells them not to follow men in a carnal way, Paul turns around and says in I Corinthians 4:15, **"For though ye have ten thousand instructors in Christ, yet have ye not many fathers: for in Christ Jesus *I have begotten you through the gospel."***

What gospel did Paul preach? The Gospel of the Grace of God, the message that he records in I Corinthians 15:3, 4, **"For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures."** This is the gospel that Paul preached. Anyone who is saved in this dispensation is saved because they believe this message. They may not even realize that it was first preached by Paul, but if they are saved today, it is because they believe this message.

In this sense, everyone who is saved today, is begotten because of what Paul preached. This is why he says, "You may have ten thousand teachers in Christ." Here is where you get into the personalities - liking this teacher better than that teacher. "You may have ten thousand teachers, but you don't have many fathers. I have begotten you with the gospel. That's how you were saved." And this is how we are saved: by the gospel that Paul preached. This is why he goes on to say in verse 16, not on the basis of personality, not on the basis of who looks better, or sounds better, but on the basis of the gospel he preached. **"For I beseech you, be ye followers of me"** (I Corinthians 4:16).

Are you following a man instead of the Lord when you follow Paul? He explains further in I Corinthians 11:1, **"Be ye followers of me *even as I also am of Christ."*** Who are we really following? We are following Christ, but we are following Him in a certain way. We are following Him the way Paul followed Him.

Can we follow Christ the way the Twelve Apostles followed Christ? We cannot, and here is why: Christ is not here today in the flesh. He's not walking down the street today in a body that we see. So how do we follow Him? The word "follow" as it is used in the Scripture means "to imitate". We are to imitate Christ the way Paul did.

Let us see how the Twelve Apostles were to follow Christ. Matthew 23:1 says, **"Then spake Jesus to the multitude, and to his disciples, saying, The scribes and the Pharisees sit in Moses' seat** [the seat of authority given to Moses under the Law]**: All therefore whatsoever they bid you observe, that observe and do; but do not ye after their works: for they say, and do not.'"** Here the Lord Jesus Christ is telling His twelve disciples how to follow Him - by observing the Law of Moses. Is that how we follow Christ? Absolutely not. Paul says **"we are not under the law, but under grace"** (Romans 6:14b).

Furthermore, we **cannot** follow the Lord in that way. Part of following the Law means worshipping at the Jewish temple. Acts 2 & 3 are some surprising verses to many people as we see that the Twelve Apostles continued to worship at the Jewish temple even after the Lord had

ascended from the earth into heaven. Acts 2:44, **"And all that believed were together, and had all things common; and sold their possessions and goods, and parted them to all men, as every man had need."** That is not God's program for today, but that was His program for the Jews at that time. Christ had told them to sell what they had, give alms to the poor, and come and follow Him, and they did it. Verse 46 says, **"And they, continuing daily with one accord *in the temple*, and breaking bread from house to house."** This was the breaking of their daily bread, their food, because they had all things in common now.

Acts 3:1, **"Now Peter and John went up together *into the temple* at the hour of prayer, being the ninth hour."** Why are they doing that? Some people say they were Jews and were used to doing that. Does God want us to do that today? No. In fact, we cannot, for there is no Jewish temple today. Where would we go to do this? How could we follow the Lord the way the Twelve Apostles did? It is impossible, and cannot be done today.

But how did Paul follow the Lord? He did not follow the Lord in His earthly ministry. Paul wasn't even a believer when Christ walked this earth. He followed the Lord after the Lord's ascension and after the Israelite nation had been set aside. Then, Paul began following the ascended and exalted Lord Jesus Christ. This is how we are to follow Him. The new way to follow Him has to do with a new program, a new spiritual ministry. Are we following a man instead of the Lord? No, we're following the Lord as Paul did, because that's what the Scripture tells us to do.

At about this point when you explain the Grace message to someone, it starts to dawn on them what you are really saying. "If what you are saying is true, then that means that Matthew, Mark, Luke and John really don't lay out the Christian walk and worship, but rather those are the Jewish Kingdom principles of living and worshipping." Accepting this fact is very hard for some people. If you are like most denominational people, you were taught from Sunday School on that the Beatitudes, the Sermon on the Mount, the parables of Jesus, are all the principles of living for today.

So when someone tells you to follow the Lord as Paul did, not as the Twelve Apostles did, what do you do with those Four Gospels? Those are the very words of the Lord Jesus Christ. And this leads to the next question:

3) Aren't the words of Christ more important than the words of Paul?

Who could argue with that? Aren't the words of Christ more important? We even have that impressed on us with the red letter edition of the Bible. The red words have to be more important than the black ones, don't they? If Christ is saying one thing, and Paul is saying another, which one are we to believe? Nobody in their right mind would believe Paul if they could believe Christ. Here again the Scripture is very clear to explain.

I Corinthians 14:37, **"If any man think himself to be a prophet, or spiritual, let him acknowledge that the things that I write unto you are the commandments of the Lord."** Paul's writings are the words of Christ!

Paul's epistles should be read [or red]! Every single word that God inspired is the Word of God. It is all His Word! But we must understand that He revealed himself differently at different times to different people.

Paul's epistles are the words of Christ to us today. For those who doubt this, Paul has a very solemn word in II Corinthians 13. Paul had the same problem in his day that we have today. People questioned whether he was really giving them the word of Christ. People doubted that he was even a real apostle. So in II Corinthians13:1-3 he writes, "**This is the third time I am coming to you.** [He's sounding like an upset parent.] **In the mouth of two or three witnesses shall every word be established. I told you before, and foretell you, as if I were present, the second time; and being absent now I write to them which heretofore have sinned, and to all other, that, if I come again, I will not spare: since ye seek a proof of Christ speaking in me."**

The Corinthians were saying, "prove it Paul, prove that Christ is speaking in you." And Paul is saying he will prove it next time he comes. At that time, how did he do it? Through signs, wonders, miracles. Now that the Word of God is complete, we simply take it because God has revealed it to us and we believe it. We do not need a sign or miracle to prove it anymore. Paul says, "This is the third time you seek a proof. I'll give it to you. Christ is speaking in me."

Yes, we are to follow Christ, we are to follow the Words of Christ, as they were revealed to the Apostle Paul. We must preach and believe the gospel as was revealed to the Apostle Paul. Christ taught a gospel - the Gospel of the

Kingdom. But under that gospel, He taught that if you want eternal life, you must keep the commandments (Matthew 19:17). It was Paul who first taught the simple gospel of faith, believe that Christ died for your sins, was buried and rose again the third day (I Corinthians 15:3, 4).

Have you been saved by believing the Gospel of Grace preached by Paul? If you haven't, you can be saved today by faith.

4) Isn't Paul just one of the other Twelve Apostles?

This writer remembers as a young person having a discussion with some other Christian youth when someone raised the question of how many apostles there were. One fellow answered, after thinking about it for awhile, that there were thirteen. He knew there were twelve but he also knew that Paul was out there for some reason or another. Does this not seem like an odd number? Why are there thirteen apostles? Many people never stop and think about this. Why would God have thirteen apostles? Twelve seems like such a nice round number.

Paul is not one of the Twelve. The Twelve Apostles are the apostles of Israel. It makes perfect sense, doesn't it? After all, how many tribes are there in Israel? Twelve. Therefore, it would make perfect sense that God should appoint an apostle for each tribe. In Matthew 19:27, Peter asks the Lord a question. He had been faithful to the Lord. The Lord had told his followers when, He was on the earth, to sell what they had, give to the poor, and follow Him. Peter wondered if there was any benefit to having done this. **"Then answered Peter and said unto**

him, Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore? And Jesus said unto them, Verily, I say unto you, that ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, *ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel"* (Matthew 19:27, 28). Paul will not be on one of those thrones. Matthew 10 lists the names of the Twelve Apostles, and Paul is not among them. Even when Judas fell because of transgression, he was replaced with Matthias (Acts 1:24-26). The Twelve Apostles will be intact when God raises them to establish the Kingdom.

But that still leaves this other Apostle. Where did this Paul come from? Most believers know that first he was Saul of Tarsus. He was raised under the law, he was raised as many young Jewish boys were raised in his day. Although he was from Tarsus which was a Roman city, he was raised under the sound of the Law, under the teaching of Gamaliel, the chief teacher of the law in Jerusalem. Before Paul was the Apostle of the Gentiles, he was simply Saul of Tarsus. He was the chief of sinners. He was the leader of the rebellion against Christ and those who were following Christ according to the Kingdom Gospel.

Galatians 1:15 says, **"But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother's womb, and called me by his grace, to reveal his Son in me, that I might preach him among the heathen; immediately I conferred not with flesh and blood."** What would we normally think would happen when a new person at that time comes to understand who Christ is? You would think they would want to get together with the Twelve

Apostles, because in that generation, they were still around and they would be the ones who would know the most about the Lord. You might think that Saul of Tarsus would surely go and see those other apostles and sit under their teaching for awhile, yet Paul makes it clear that he did not do that.

Galatians 1:17 continues, **"Neither went I up to Jerusalem to them which were apostles before me; but I went into Arabia, and returned again unto Damascus. Then, after three years I went up to Jerusalem to see Peter."** The word "see" is "to get acquainted with". He didn't even go up to be taught at that time. He just went to meet Peter and get to know who he was. All of this took place three years after Paul met the Lord. It is very obvious that the Apostle Paul did not immediately go and become associated with the Twelve Apostles. As one goes through the rest of Galatians 1 & 2, Paul goes to great lengths to disassociate himself with the other apostles. This is not because he did not like them, it is simply because God gave him a new ministry and a new message to take to the Gentiles. Paul wants to make it clear that he did not get his message or his apostleship from the Twelve Apostles.

Once we understand this, it puts a whole new perspective on the Word of God, does it not? Now we can see that Paul's epistles have a special place in God's program for today. This leads us to another question:

5) How do we know what is written directly to us?

If some Scripture is addressed to Israel and some to these people over here in Corinth and some to the Romans, who

knows what is written to us? Again, the answer is very simple. Read the address.

We might go down to the Post Office and ask the Postmaster how they keep all the letters straight. How do they make sure they get the right letter in the right mailbox? You look at the address. It's that simple.

Most Bible teachers will tell you that this present age began on the day of Pentecost. We believe it began with the ministry of the Apostle Paul. In Acts 2:22 we read, **"Ye men of Israel, hear these words."** And in verse 36, **"Therefore let all the house of Israel know assuredly, that God has made that same Jesus, whom ye have crucified, both Lord and Christ."** But some will say there were Gentiles there too, in the crowd. The answer is yes, there were, but the Scripture is very careful to identify them for us. Acts 2:9, 10 says, *"***Parthians, and Medes, and Elamites, and the dwellers in Mesopotamia, and in Judea, and Cappadocia, in Pontus, and Asia, Phrygia, and Pamphylia, in Egypt, and in the parts of Libya about Cyrene, and strangers of Rome, Jews and proselytes."** The only Gentiles recorded are those who have already converted over to the Jewish religion, which means that again, Peter is addressing those who are already involved in Jewish worship. Verse 14, "**Ye men of Judea, and all ye that dwell at Jerusalem."** It is so important to read the address.

Another book that many people have stumbled over is James. Martin Luther was ready to throw the book of James out of the Bible. He called it an Epistle of Straw. He thought it had no substance to it. Why? Because the

book of James says, **"Without works your faith is dead. A man is justified by works and not by faith only"** (see James 2:17, 24). Martin Luther, the great champion of justification by faith said James cannot be right and he was ready to get rid of it. Of course, he needed to read the address, too. The book of James says in the very first verse, "**James, to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad."** Much confusion would be done away with if we would just read the address.

In I Timothy 2:7, Paul had some frustration. Here he came with a new message and people were questioning it. After all, they had the Law for 1500 years, they'd had the prophets, and the Twelve Apostles, and now here comes this man claiming to have a new revelation from God. It is easy to see why people would question this and be a little bit skeptical. Paul writes in I Timothy 2:7, **"Where unto I am ordained a preacher and an apostle, I speak the truth in Christ and lie not."** You can just sense his frustration! He says, I'm not lying to you, I'm telling the truth. This is what Christ gave to me. There is passage after passage where Paul says, "I am the Apostle to the Gentiles. Unto me was committed the dispensation of the Grace of God for you Gentiles." Time and again he reminds us that he was given a unique revelation directed to us today. It's really quite simple. The Epistles of Paul are addressed to us.

6) If Paul's Epistles are the ones that are addressed to us, what are we to do with the rest of the Bible?

Those who do not know the Word of God rightly divided will sometimes be a little sarcastic: "Are you suggesting

we just throw away the rest of the Bible? Just tear it out and get rid of it?" Of course not. What should we do with the rest of the Bible? Read it!! Study it! Search the Scriptures! We should understand it.

Let us see what Paul says about this. Romans 15:4 says, **"For whatsoever things were written aforetime, were written for our learning, that we through patience and comfort of the scriptures might have hope."** Read the Old Testament, study it, and rightly divide it, as Paul tells us in the familiar passage in II Timothy 2:15, **"Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth."**

There is a saying the Grace movement - "all Scripture is for us, but not all Scripture is written to us, or about us." It is so important to recognize this when we search the Scriptures. It will alleviate so much confusion and anguish. How many times have we heard of people who have prayed for something because they have seen a prayer promise in the four gospels. **"Whatsoever ye shall ask in prayer believing ye shall receive"** (Matthew 21:22). They've claimed that promise, holding God to His word. And yet, maybe the months and years go by and that prayer is not answered. Does this mean God told a lie or is not faithful to His Word? No, He did not address that promise to you. He addressed it to the Kingdom saints! We need to rightly divide the word of truth.

Paul knew what it meant to rightly divide. Even from his secular occupation as a tentmaker he knew that in order to make a tent you had to make those seams come together

just so. When he chose wording and under the guidance and inspiration of the Holy Spirit, he chose a very practical term. In the Greek it's "orthotomeo" which means "straight". The orthodontist straightens your teeth, the orthopedic surgeon works on your feet to straighten them out. Orthotomeo means to cut straight. When Paul prepared some skins or fabric and started to look at his plans for a tent, he knew that he had to cut the piece straight so that this seam would fit together with that seam over there when he began sewing it. It is important that we cut straight the word of truth so that it will fit together.

Many people think that if you rightly divide the word of truth you will cut it apart. But actually, when you rightly divide, it will fit together the way God intended it to. If we rightly divide the word of truth, we will do away with the seeming contradictions and problems that many people see in the Bible.

So what do we do with the rest of Scripture? We read it. We study it. And we rightly divide the word of truth.

7) Shouldn't we keep the Ten Commandments?

The Ten Commandments are part of the Law, found back in the book of Exodus. And again, some may ask, "If Paul's Epistles are the epistles for us, does this mean we do not have to keep the Ten Commandments anymore? Does this mean it is no longer wrong to murder or to steal anymore?" Again, this is just a silly way of getting people off the track.

While pastoring in Colorado we had a family who invited an acquaintance of theirs to our church. Our church had

gotten a reputation for rightly dividing the word of truth and because of a misconception of that reputation, the acquaintance answered by saying, "I don't think so. That church doesn't believe in the Ten Commandments." The ironic thing is that right around that time we were preaching through the Ten Commandments in our Sunday School hour. If she had only bothered to come and see what we were doing, she would have found out that indeed we do study all of Scripture.

The Apostle Paul restates nine of the ten commandments in some form or another in his Epistles. So obviously, the principles behind these commandments are still carried over into this dispensation. We have a name for this - horizontal truth. These are truths that are the same from the beginning of the Bible until the end. God never condones murder. God never condones adultery and theft and lying, etc. Of course, the principles that God has established as the moral foundation of the nation of Israel still exist in this dispensation.

As you noticed, we said Paul restates nine of the ten commandments. Do you know which one he leaves out? The Sabbath - because we are not under the Sabbath system in this dispensation. You might say there is still the principle there that we should work six days and rest one day. This is true and valid. But we are not under the Sabbath as a spiritual rule by which we must abide. Furthermore, Sunday is not the Sabbath. Saturday was the Sabbath and in order to keep the Sabbath according to the Bible's way of doing it, you really could not come out to church anyway because under the law people did not meet on the Sabbath day. In fact, they were not to do much travel at all. They were to stay around home and

tend to the animals and other necessary chores, but otherwise were to totally take a day of rest. So even those groups which claim to be keeping the Sabbath often come out and violate the basis of the Sabbath keeping of the Old Testament anyway.

Does God want us to break the Ten Commandments? Of course not! The principles are still valid and Paul applies them in Romans 13:9, 10, **"For this, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not kill, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness, Thou shalt not covet; and if there by any other commandment, it is briefly comprehended in this saying, namely, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. Love worketh no ill to his neighbour; therefore love is the fulfilling of the law."** We are not under the Law. We are under Grace. But being under Grace does not mean that we disregard the moral principles of the Word of God. The way that we keep the Ten Commandments is not by having a list and making sure not to break them. The way we do it now, is to exercise Godly love to one another. When we do this, we automatically keep those principles. If you love your neighbor, you are not going to kill him. If you love your neighbor, you are not going to steal things from him. Paul boils it down to the simplicity of living under grace: just live according to love and then you will automatically fulfill the Law.

But this was not the only way the Lord taught the Ten Commandments. He did boil it down to the basic principles, of loving your neighbor and loving the Lord your God. But he also told the rich young ruler, **"If thou wilt enter into life, keep the commandments"** (Matthew 19:17). At one time, keeping the commandments was an

expression of faith. In order to show your faith, you did it through keeping the commandments. Today, we simply exercise Godly love and automatically fulfill the Law.

8) If Paul was given a new revelation, why does he quote the Old Testament so many times?

The Apostle Paul quotes the Old Testament more than any other New Testament writer. Why does he do this if he was given a new revelation? Paul uses the Old Testament in two ways. The first way is to point out those horizontal truths which are consistent in every dispensation. An example is Ephesians 6:1-3, **"Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right. Honour thy father and mother; which is the first commandment with promise; That it may by well with thee, and thou mayest live long on the earth."** Paul quotes an Old Testament passage simply to show a truth that continues on in every dispensation. Children are to obey their parents today just as much as they would obey their parents back under the Law. It is a universal principle of God.

The second way Paul uses the Old Testament is to illustrate a point. An example of this is Romans 4:1-3, **"What shall we say then that Abraham our father, as pertaining to the flesh, hath found? For if Abraham were justified by works, he hath whereof to glory; but not before God. For what saith the scripture? Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness."** Why does Paul quote this passage? It is to illustrate a point: faith. What is faith? It is believing what God says. It is simply taking God at His

word. But is Paul drawing into this dispensation the same object of faith which Abraham had? What did Abraham believe? God told Abraham his seed would be as numerous as the stars of the sky. Abraham believed God. Does this mean that we can be saved today by having the same object of faith that Abraham had? Would you be saved if you believed that you would have as many children as there are stars in the sky? First of all, you probably will not have that many descendants, and secondly, it wouldn't matter if you believed this or not. This is not the object of our faith.

Paul does not go back there to bring in the object of your faith. He's illustrating a point. Believe what God says! Believe what God says to YOU! Paul's point is that God has something He wants you to believe in order to be justified. Just as Abraham believed what God told him, you must believe what God tells you, and you will be justified by faith. What has God told us? Paul says in I Corinthians 15:3, 4, **"For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures, that he was buried and he rose again the third day according to the scriptures."** Believe this and be saved! Notice how Paul emphasizes this point in Romans 4:4, **"Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt. But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness."** So the message of God to us today is simply believe the Gospel of Christ's finished work, His death, burial and resurrection. Do not add any works whatsoever to that gospel. Believe and be saved.

Why does Paul quote the Old Testament? To illustrate a

point, to show principles that still exist. But not to bring us back under the Old Testament economy.

9) Why don't you water baptize?

Nowhere in Paul's epistles do you ever find instructions for us to be water baptized. Many recognize that Paul was given revelation from the Lord and that in fact, he writes directly to the churches and the church leaders, Timothy and Titus and to the saints of the Body of Christ. Yet, does it not strike you as a little strange that if we are supposed to be water baptizing that Paul never tells us to do it. He never tells us how it is supposed to be done, how it should be carried out, who should be doing it, etc. Why is this?

True Christianity is a faith which involves an inward reality, not outward ritual. And yet even as we write this, the vast majority of Christendom, has reverted back to the rituals of the Law and the Jewish Kingdom program.

Israel was a sign nation. God revealed to the Jewish people many outward shows of their faith. These involved sacrifices, water rituals and ceremonial washings, certain meats and drinks, observance of days, etc. All of these being designed to teach certain truths to the nation Israel. As one examines God's spiritual program for this dispensation, however, as it is revealed to the Apostle of the Gentiles, the Apostle Paul, it soon becomes evident that these outward, visible manifestations of Israel's religion, do not belong to the Church the Body of Christ. Indeed, they have no place in the practice of our faith in this dispensation. Amazingly, many churches would agree. They would say, of course, we do not observe those Jewish rituals. We have instead

our own Christian rituals that we do! Many fail to realize that the so-called Christian ordinances and rituals actually can be traced back to the Jewish program for the nation Israel.

I Corinthians 1:17 says, **"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel: not with wisdom of words, lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect."** Water baptism is not a part of Paul's commission. Later on we will discuss the Great Commission. One of the reasons many people teach that we should be water baptized is because it is a part of the Great Commission given to the Twelve Apostles. We will deal with that in depth later. But what we need to see here is the Apostle Peter and the other Eleven Apostles could not have said what Paul says here in I Corinthians 1, **"Christ sent me not to baptize."** Peter would have been telling a lie if he had said this, because Christ ***did*** send him to baptize. **"Go ye therefore, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit"** (Matthew 28:19). Paul was not operating under the commission given to the Twelve Apostles, and neither are we. That Commission was a Kingdom Commission.

Where did water baptism come from and who was the first person who practiced water baptism? Perhaps 99 out of 100 would answer, John the Baptist. He certainly sounds like one who would be the first to baptize. His name is John the Baptist (or "baptizer"). Why was he called the baptizer? Was he doing something new? No, not at all. Hebrews 9:10 speaks of the "diverse washings" of the Old Testament tabernacle. In the Old Testament, every time you read of a washing at the door of the

tabernacle, it is a "baptism". For the word translated "washings" in Hebrews 9:10 is "baptizmos" or baptisms. Baptisms did not begin with John the Baptist. He was just continuing that which had been practiced for hundreds of years.

Ephesians 4:3 says, **"Endeavouring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. There is one body..."** This is the Body of Christ. Then, in verse 5, Paul continues, **"There is One Lord, one faith, <u>one baptism</u>..."**

This verse has probably been more obscured by theologians than any verse in the Bible. It is not that they have never read it, but that they fail to grasp Paul's point. When we search the Scriptures we find that there are as many as twelve baptisms. Some of these are water baptisms of the Law, others are spiritual in nature. In Matthew 3:11, John the Baptist said, **"I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance: but he that cometh after me is mightier than I, whose shoes I am not worthy to bear: he shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire."** Right here in this context we see three baptisms - water, Holy Spirit and fire.

Yet, Paul says there is one baptism! Did Paul not know the Scriptures? Of course he did, but Paul is speaking in the context of the Body of Christ and his conclusion is that while there are many baptisms in the Bible - twelve or more - only one of them pertains to us in this dispensation of the Grace of God. Which one do you suppose it is?

I Corinthians 12:12, 13 says, **"For as the body is one,**

and hath many members, and all the members of that one body, being many, are one body: so also is Christ. For by one Spirit are we all <u>baptized into one body</u>." Here is a spiritual baptism. This baptism has no water whatsoever. It is performed by the Holy Spirit of God. It happens the moment you believe the gospel of Christ's death, burial and resurrection. The Holy Spirit supernaturally baptizes you into the Body of Christ. Another translation of the word "baptize" is the word "identify", because that is what happens when we are saved. We become identified with Christ. What three things did we believe in order to be saved? His death, His burial and His resurrection. What three things are we identified with when we trust him? His death, His burial and His resurrection.

This is what Paul is speaking of in Romans 6. Many a fundamentalist preacher is very adamant that this is not a water baptism. And yet, it seems as though by the time they dance all around the subject of baptism, they finally managed to squeeze a few drops of water out of Romans 6. Why is this? It is an attempt to prove a point which cannot be proven from Scripture. Romans 6:3, **"Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ..."** When you believed the gospel the Holy Spirit identified you with Christ. What happened then? **"...as many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death?"** You became identified with the death of Christ. What is so important about that? The Scripture says, **"All have sinned and come short of the glory of God"** (Romans 3:23). Furthermore it says, "**the wages of sin is death"** (Romans 6:23). That is spiritual death as well as physical death. Because we are sinful, we must die. We must pay the penalty of sin with our

life. But this is what the gospel is all about. Christ came and paid the penalty of sin by dying for us. Therefore, when you believe the gospel, you are baptized or identified with Jesus Christ, and therefore you are baptized into His death. This means you no longer must die spiritually for your sins, because His death is accounted to you. It now belongs to you. And you, therefore, have eternal life. This is the gospel message.

But not only are we identified with His death, verse 4 says, **"Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death."** This is the verse where many get the idea that believers should be dunked under water. They assume that since we are buried, we should, therefore, be put in a "watery grave." But this not only misses the point, it actually totally destroys the meaning that Paul is trying to show. He is not saying you were buried in water. He says you were buried with Christ. His burial becomes your burial by virtue of your baptism into His death. Paul is building on that truth now. Not only are you identified with His death (you no longer have to die for your sins), but you are buried with Him as well.

What is the importance of the burial of Christ? First, it shows Christ really died. You do not bury people who are not dead. He was truly dead and therefore, He was buried. But it also pictures the putting away of sin. When Christ rose from that grave, our sins stayed buried. This is the imagery that God wants us to see. The fact that we are identified with His death relieves us from having to die for our sins. The fact that we are buried with Him means that those sins are done away with, and finally, we are identified with His resurrection, because of spiritual baptism!

Finally, verse 4 goes on to say, **"...that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life."** Because of our identification with Christ, we now have the spiritual equipment by the Holy Spirit to live the Christian life. This is what spiritual baptism is all about. Why would we trade all this for a water ceremony?

10) Why was Jesus baptized?

Why was Christ baptized? Most assume that if He did it, surely we should do it, too. Let us consider why Christ was baptized in ***His own words***. John the Baptist had this same question on his mind when Christ came to be baptized of him. John said, "Why are you coming to be baptized by me? I need to be baptized by you!" Why would John have said that? Because at that time, water baptism was associated with cleansing from sin (see Mark 1:4). John knew that Christ had no sin, so he is wondering why Christ would need to be baptized. Notice the Lord's answer: Matthew 3:13-15, **"Then cometh Jesus from Galilee to Jordan unto John, to be baptized of him. But John forbad him, saying, I have need to be baptized of thee, and comest thou to me? And Jesus answering said unto him, 'Suffer it to be so now: for thus it becometh us to fulfil all righteousness.' Then he suffered him."**

What did the Lord mean when He said "it becometh us to fulfil all righteousness"? Why did Christ come to the nation of Israel? Did He come to destroy the Law with its ordinances or to do away with the prophets? Christ Himself said, **"Think not that I am come to destroy the Law or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to**

fulfil" (Matthew 5:17). The Lord Jesus Christ, the perfect Son of God, came to identify with the human race and in particular with the nation of Israel. In doing so, He submitted Himself to all of the laws of the nation of Israel, including the water washings or baptisms. In order to identify with sinners, even though He was sinless, He partook of this water washing which symbolized a cleansing for the nation of Israel. He came and partook of the same so He would become one with them. Furthermore, it is interesting to note that water baptism was required for the priestly tribe when they were initiated into the priesthood (Exodus 40:12). Priests were to enter the ministry at thirty years of age, which is exactly how old Christ was when He entered His earthly ministry and became water baptized according to the Law of Moses.

We are not under the Law today. The Lord Jesus Christ was circumcised on the eighth day in the temple, He worshipped at the temple, and He partook of the Jewish feasts. Are we to do all of those things today? Of course not. We are not under the law, therefore, we are not subject to the water washings of the Old Testament law.

Another verse which shows why Jesus was baptized is John 1:29-31, *"***The next day John seeth Jesus coming unto him, and saith, Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world. This is he of whom I said, After me cometh a man which is preferred before me: for he was before me. And I knew him not: but that he should be made manifest to Israel, therefore am I come baptizing with water."** John's baptism was to manifest Christ to Israel. How would the baptism of Christ reveal Him to Israel? God had told John to watch

for the Spirit to descend like a dove. As he baptized, the One on whom the Spirit descended and remained, would be identified as the Messiah. **"And I knew him not: but he that sent me to baptize with water, the same said unto me, Upon whom thou shalt see the Spirit descending, and remaining on him, the same is he which baptizeth with the Holy Ghost"** (John 1:33).

11) If water baptism was a part of the Jewish law, and if it's really not intended for us, and if God has given us a spiritual baptism, why did Paul baptize?

Why did Paul baptize? I Corinthians 13:12 gives us a principle which will help us to understand why Paul baptized with water in his early ministry. **"For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part."** What is Paul talking about? When he wrote I Corinthians, he had only received a small portion of the full revelation that would eventually be given to him. There came a time when God did reveal the fullness of the mystery to the Apostle Paul. But when he wrote I Corinthians, he said he only knew in part. This explains why Paul continued a Jewish practice as long as he did. We can pinpoint when Paul stopped baptizing according to Scriptures. In Acts 18 at Corinth, Paul water baptized. He refers to this in I Corinthians 1:14-16, **"I thank God that I baptized none of you, but Crispus and Gaius; Lest any should say that I had baptized in mine own name. And I baptized also the household of Stephanas: besides, I know not whether I baptized any other."**

Paul had gotten a revelation concerning water baptism

between Acts 18 and when he wrote I Corinthians. This is a space of about two years. We can pinpoint that during that two year period Paul received further revelation that water baptism was not a part of his commission for this Dispensation of Grace. This is what we call progressive revelation. By the time he wrote I Corinthians, Paul could confidently state, **"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel"** (I Corinthians 1:17).

God did not give the whole program to Paul all at one time. He progressively revealed it. And Paul did what any of us would do if we wanted to be faithful to the Lord. As we learn, we change. We practice what we know to practice until we learn otherwise. And when Paul learned that water baptism was not a part of this dispensation, there is not one more instance of Paul baptizing anyone after that time.

12) What harm is there in water baptism?

Many recognize and understand that water baptism does not save us. They understand that we are not under the law. But really, what harm is there in going through this little ceremony? The most obvious danger is trusting in baptism rather than trusting in Christ. There are many churches today which teach salvation by baptism. We call this doctrine "Baptismal Regeneration". Major denominations teach that the way to be saved is to be baptized with water. Why is this dangerous? Many young people are baptized with water as a child and as they grow, they are taught this took away their original sin. Or they are taught that this baptism places them into the Kingdom of God. This is tragic and it flies in the face of what Paul taught. **"For by grace are ye saved**

through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: not of works, lest any man should boast" (Ephesians 2:8, 9).

Many evangelical, fundamental churches do not teach salvation by baptism, but they will not allow you to be a member of their church unless you have been baptized. God will accept you, but they will not. Some will "sort of" accept you, but you are not considered to be in the will of God if you do not do it.

Others would say baptism is just an outward sign of an inward reality, and that being dunked in water pictures what we believe. We believe we have been buried with Christ. We believe we have been raised again and baptism is said to be a ceremony to show this. But we should ask "Why?" Where does the word of God ever tell us that baptism is to show someone you are saved? The fact is it doesn't. Many point to Romans 6, which is not referring to water baptism at all (see question #9).

The harm, aside from the danger of clinging to baptism as your point of salvation, is the shadow water baptism casts on the message of the gospel. Colossians 2:8 says, **"Beware lest any man spoil you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, after the rudiments of the world, and not after Christ."**

Paul says to "beware". Some would try to strip something from you, steal something from you. This is what is meant by the word "spoil". But what is it they want to steal from us? Verse 9 says, "**For in him** [Christ] **dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily."** And in verse 10, **"And ye are complete in him."** We are

complete in Him! What can you add to that? Baptism? A water washing? A ceremony? We are complete in Him. What does this say if we say we are saved, but yet there is a next step, if you want to really have everything - be baptized. What is that saying about your salvation? It is saying that something is missing. But Paul wrote that we are complete IN HIM! The Jew would ask, "Don't I need to be circumcised?" Verse 11 answers, **"In whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands. In putting off the body of the sins of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ."**

Many today would ask, "Don't we need to be baptized?" Verse 12 answers, **"Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead."** Paul's message is that you do not need to be circumcised, you do not need to be baptized, because you already are! You are complete in Christ. You already have these things. To go back and do them for a religious purpose casts a reflection on the finished work of Christ. It is as though you are saying you really do not believe that what Christ did was quite good enough, and that it set me in perfectly good standing with God, so you are going to add just a little bit more to it. Water baptism casts a reflection on the finished work of Christ, and this is why it is dangerous!

Paul goes on to illustrate it in verse 14, **"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us."** Baptism was an ordinance. Many churches will tell you there are ordinances for today. Scripture says there are not. They have been blotted out. Verse 16 says, **"Let no man therefore judge you in meat, or in drink, or in**

respect of an holyday, or of the new moon, or of the sabbath days: which are a shadow of things to come; but the body [the substance, the real thing] **is of Christ."** Baptism was a shadow - Christ is the real thing. Which would you rather have? Paul says in Christ you already have the real thing. Do not go back to the shadow. Do not go back to that which has no substance. Glory in Christ. He is the real thing!

If you told your son to carry out the trash and told your daughter to do the dishes, would they be considered obedient children if your son would do the dishes and your daughter would carry out the trash? No, we might commend them for doing something, but they really could not be obedient if they did not do what you told them to do. In the final analysis, we would have to conclude they were unfaithful servants. This is a simple illustration and yet in essence, it describes what the church has been doing or trying to do for the last 2,000 years. By and large, the church has been trying to carry out the final instructions of our Lord to the Twelve Apostles, often known as the Great Commission. One of the common questions which arises when we talk about the unique and distinctive message committed to the Apostle Paul is the question:

13) Aren't we supposed to be carrying out the Great Commission?

To answer the question, let's take a mental stroll through the Bible. From the fall of Adam and Eve until this present day, God has always sought the salvation of mankind. He has always provided some way for man to approach Him on His terms. Throughout the ages, God has even gone the extra step of commissioning certain

individuals or groups to carry His message to the people of the earth so that they clearly understand just what God expects of them. Before the flood, Noah was commissioned as a preacher of righteousness. For 120 years, as he was building that ark, he proclaimed God's righteousness to an increasingly sinful and wicked world.

After the flood, the world soon turned away from God once again. Mankind showed its rebellion against God by building a tower and a city to make a name for themselves. To this day we know the name of that tower - the Tower of Babel, the city of Babylon. At this point, God commissioned someone else to become a separate nation through whom He could reach these unbelieving Gentile nations. That person was Abram, soon to become Abraham. This nation, which eventually was known as the nation of Israel, inherited the commission to be a light to the other nations, to lead them to the true and living God. Here is how it was supposed to work: God promised the people of Israel that if they would obey His covenant, then He would be their God and they would be His people. As the nations round about Israel looked at the blessing of God falling upon this one nation, they would ask why they were so blessed? Then they would come and inquire, and Israel would point them to their God and say, "We're blessed because we serve the living and true God."

Let us give an Old Testament passage to illustrate how this was supposed to operate. This was God's order for bringing the nations of the earth to Himself through Israel. We sometimes call this the Kingdom program or the prophetic program. We call it the prophetic program because it was revealed in the prophets. It was spoken of

by the mouth of all the holy prophets since the world began (Acts 3:21). Isaiah 60:1-3, **"Arise, shine; for thy light is come, and the glory of the Lord is risen upon thee. For, behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, and gross darkness the people: but the Lord shall arise upon thee, and his glory shall be seen upon thee."** Who is He talking about? In this context, He is referring to Zion. Zion is another name for Jerusalem, the capital city of the nation of Israel, in biblical times. In verse 3 we read, **"And the Gentiles shall come to thy light, and kings to the brightness of thy rising."** God's intention and plan was to bring Israel as a light to the nations and to lift her up on high so that the nations would see that light and so that kings would seek out the glory of God through Israel. This was how it was supposed to work. But unfortunately, many times, it did not work that way. Israel, as the centuries rolled on, failed to be the light that God wanted her to be. Israel, herself, slipped into apostasy. She slipped away from the truth of God's word and God's revelation to her. This was the condition that Christ found her in when He came to the earth as a babe in the manger. As our Lord ministered on the earth, His first commission to His apostles was not for them to go out unto all the world. In order for the world to be saved according to that kingdom or prophetic program through the nation of Israel, first Israel had to rise up as a great light. Israel herself was in great darkness when Christ came.

Notice how He first commissioned His apostles. Matthew 10:1-4: **"And when he had called unto him his twelve disciples, he gave them power against unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal all manner of sickness and all manner of disease. Now the names of the**

twelve apostles are these: The first, Simon, who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother; James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother; Philip, and Bartholomew; Thomas, and Matthew the publican; James the son of Alphaeus, and Lebbeaus, whose surname was Thaddaeus; Simon the Canaanite, and Judas Iscariot, who also betrayed him."

Verse 5, **"These twelve Jesus sent forth, and commanded them, saying, 'Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not.'"** We should ask the question, why not? Did not God love the Gentile nations at this time? Did not Christ desire to see them saved? Of course He did. But He was operating according to knowledge and understanding that God would bring His light to the nations through Israel. If Israel herself was lost, she first needed to come to the Lord, then Israel could be a light to the nations. This is why He says in verse 6, **"But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand."** In Matthew 15 we see that this commission applied even to our Lord. Matthew 15:21 says, **"Then Jesus went thence, and departed into the coasts of Tyre and Sidon. And, behold, a woman of Canaan came out of the same coasts."** Notice that the Holy Spirit inspires the writer to show us this is a Gentile woman; a woman of Canaan. Why is that so important? Because of what the Lord is about to say. She comes with a request in verse 22: **"She cried unto him, saying, Have mercy on me, O Lord, thou son of David; my daughter is grievously vexed with a devil. But he answered her not a word. And his disciples came and besought him, saying, Send her away; for she crieth after us. But he answered and**

said, I am not sent but unto the lost sheep of the house of Israel." Does that sound like our loving, caring Lord? He does not even talk to her. Why does He do this?

Verse 25, **"Then came she and worshipped him, saying, Lord, help me. But he answered and said, It is not meet to take the children's bread, and to cast it to dogs."** This is going from bad to worse it seems. The Lord knew His commission, didn't He? He knew he was sent to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. He knew that the nations could not be blessed until the children were filled. What children? The children of Israel. Let the children first be filled. But notice her faith in verse 27, **"And she said, Truth, Lord."** Her answer shows that she understood the program under which she lived. She understood she did not have a claim on God's blessings directly. She understood she did not have access to the glorious blessings that God promised to Israel. But then notice her statement of faith, **"Yet the dogs eat of the crumbs which fall from their masters' table."** She is saying in effect, Lord I don't expect the direct blessing that you have promised to your children of Israel. I do not expect that. I just want a few leftovers. I just want a few crumbs. The Lord at that point saw her great faith and so He blessed her. Verse 28, **"Then Jesus answered and said unto her, O woman, great is thy faith: be it unto thee even as thou wilt. And her daughter was made whole from that very hour."**

You see that principle being well established that the nations are not to be blessed under this kingdom and prophetic program until Israel is first blessed. Once Israel was straightened out, then and only then, was the message to go out to the nations. Christ made this perfectly clear

when He commissioned the twelve apostles.

Luke 24:46, **"And said unto them, Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day: And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem."** Here is that same principle. Let the children first be filled. Acts 1:8, *"***But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth."** When Israel was filled, then the message could go on to the nations. The only problem was that Israel rejected the kingdom offer.

This was a problem from our point of view. But was it a problem for God? Of course not. God had in His mind a plan by which He could reach the nations in spite of the stubbornness of Israel. He had a plan whereby the nations could hear His word and they would not have to come through Israel's rising. Remember Isaiah 60:3 where God says the nations would come to the light of Israel's rising. Now consider a contrast to that in Romans 11:11. Here the Apostle Paul draws a contrast between how God reaches the nations today as opposed to how the prophets spoke of Israel's rising. Under the prophetic program, the kingdom program, the nations were to be reached through Israel's rising. But in Romans 11:11 we read, **"I say then, Have they stumbled that they should fall?** [Referring to Israel] **God forbid: but rather through their fall salvation is come unto the Gentiles, for to provoke them to jealousy."** Do you see the difference? In Isaiah, the nations are to come through Israel's rising.

In Romans, the nations are blessed through Israel's fall. How can that be? And how does that tie into the Great Commission?

God revealed his plan to reach the nations in spite of Israel through the Apostle Paul. God determined that if Israel would not go to the nations, He would temporarily by-pass that nation and go directly to the Gentiles. He chose a messenger by the name of Saul of Tarsus to become the great apostle of the Gentiles. When He did so, He temporarily suspended the Great Commission which was given to the Twelve. This leads to the next questions:

14) Where in Scripture do we ever find the Great Commission that was given to the Twelve being suspended?

This is a good question. Most churches today operate under the Great Commission. They believe there has been no interruption of the Great Commission from the time it was given until this day. But in fact, its suspension was recognized at the Jerusalem Council. In Galatians 2, Paul explains why he had a meeting with the remainder of the Twelve Apostles. In Galatians 2:7-9 we read, **"But contrariwise, when they** [Apostles] **saw that the gospel of the uncircumcision was committed unto me, as the gospel of the circumcision was unto Peter."** Uncircumcision means those who were not a part of the Jewish program. Circumcision was a Jewish ritual. He is talking about a message which does not include rituals, does not include the law, and the keeping of the law, and all of the other ordinances that went along with it. "**When they saw that the gospel of the uncircumcision**

was committed unto me [Paul says], **as the gospel of the circumcision was committed unto Peter: (For he that wrought effectually in Peter to the apostleship of the circumcision, the same was mighty in me toward the Gentiles:) And when James, Cephas, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship; that we should go unto the heathen, and they unto the circumcision."** But how can they do that? At least two of these men were right there when the Lord told them to go into all the world beginning in Jerusalem, and Judea, and Samara, and then unto the uttermost part of the earth.

How could Peter and John who were standing with the Lord when He said they were to go into all the world, now suddenly say, "We won't go to the nations anymore. Paul, you do that. We will go to the circumcision." How can they do that? They can do it because God revealed something new to them. He revealed that God had now begun a new program in order to bring salvation to the nations. It was not going to be according to the Great Commission He had given them. It included a different message. Not only was the responsibility being transferred to a new apostle, the Apostle Paul, but a new message was being committed to him as well. So the answer to the question, "Where is the Great Commission suspended?" is right here in Galatians 2:9 - where the remainder of the Twelve Apostles recognize that God has given a new ministry to Paul, and God has given a new message to Paul. It was no longer their task to go to the nations anymore and they stopped at that point. Paul and the new program took over with the Gospel of the Grace of God.

With that background we will now go back and look at the various accounts of the Great Commission and see that it cannot be carried out today, at least not the way the Lord told them to do it. Matthew 28:18 says, **"And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world."** Many people try to carry out these instructions; yet they cannot and still be scriptural in this dispensation of Grace. Why is this? Because for one thing - to carry out the Great Commission, as recorded here, means you must bind your followers to the Law of Moses. Some will ask "where does it say that?" Notice the first part of verse 20, **"Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you."** Did the Lord Jesus Christ ever command his disciples to be subject to the Law of Moses? Yes, indeed. In Matthew 23:1-3 we read, **"Then spake Jesus to the multitude, and to his disciples, Saying, The scribes and the Pharisees sit in Moses' seat."** This is the seat of the Law, the authority of the Law. **"All therefore whatsoever they bid you observe, that observe and do; but do not ye after their works: for they say, and do not."** Our Lord commanded His disciples to be subject to the Law of Moses. Now as He commissions them to take the kingdom gospel to the world, He says to teach them to observe all things He commanded them. What a contrast to Paul's later teaching that we are **"not under the law, but under grace"** (Romans 6:14b).

Another area which some try to do but does not work very well is the Lord's teaching to sell everything they had and to give it to the poor. He taught that on more than one occasion. (See Matthew 19:21 & Luke 12:33). Did they teach those that they reached to do the same thing? They certainly did! Read Acts 2 and 4 where the early disciples of the Twelve sold everything they had and they laid the money at the apostles feet. The Apostle Paul never tells us to do that. He tells us to be careful not to trust in riches, but he never tells us that we are to sell everything we have and bring it to the apostles feet. Which apostles would we take it to anyway?

Keeping the Commission of Matthew 28 would require keeping the Law, selling everything you have and laying it at the apostles' feet. Obviously, these are things we cannot do if we are going to try to keep that Kingdom Commission. A more controversial passage and one that is quoted most often is in Mark 16:15, **"And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature."** Usually this is all you ever hear quoted of the Great Commission. This part sounds wonderful. Of course, we should do that. But the details that the Lord tells them are simply not compatible with the Dispensation of Grace. This is a Kingdom commission. Verse 16 says, *"***He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved: but he that believeth not shall be damned."** Where do people get the idea that water baptism will save them? Right here in this verse. According to this commission, water baptism was required along with their faith. Does this mean that the water saved them? No. But it was an act of obedience which demonstrated their faith and if they did not do it, it

only showed they did not have faith. Some people will tell you this is true today. But the Apostle Paul is clear:

Ephesians 2:8, 9 **"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast."** Titus 3:5 **"Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of regeneration."** There was a time when water baptism was a requirement in God's program. This is not the case today.

Mark 16:17, **"And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils..."** This is a kingdom sign. What will happen to the devil in the kingdom? He will be cast out for 1,000 years. **"They shall speak with new tongues..."** What language will people speak in the kingdom? The Bible says God will give them a pure language (Zephaniah 3:9). Everyone will be able to speak the same language once again someday. God gave a gift to these people to illustrate the kingdom. That is not the case today. **"They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them."** People today try this and many times end up six feet under. This is not a commission for today. **"They shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover."** We will discuss the question of healing later, but for now let us affirm that God can heal, but He is not obligated to do so.

Luke 24:47, **"Beginning in Jerusalem..." and Acts 1:8, "...in Jerusalem, and in all Judea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth."** Many people will spiritualize this passage and say this means to start in

your own home town. For us, they say, the Great Commission is to start in your home town, then your county, and then your state, and then the United States, and so forth. Is this what the Lord was saying? Of course not. First of all, Jerusalem was not the home town of many of these disciples. He was telling them to start in Jerusalem because Jerusalem was to be the capital city of the earth, of the Kingdom program. If the capital city does not believe, what good is it going on from there?

Are we to begin in Jerusalem today? II Corinthians 5 says we are ambassadors for Christ. We are already in a foreign land. We are already missionaries right where we are. We may go wherever the Lord opens a door, but it does not have to begin in Jerusalem.

The fourth and one of the most neglected references of the Great Commission is John 20. In this account, we find that Christ entrusts the forgiveness of sins to human mediators. John 20:19-23 says, **"Then the same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where the disciples were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in the midst, and saith unto them, Peace be unto you. And when he had so said, he shewed unto them his hands and his side. Then were the disciples glad, when they saw the Lord. Then said Jesus to them again, Peace be unto you: as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you. And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, Receive ye the Holy Ghost: Whosoever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whosoever sins ye retain, they are retained."** Again, we remind you, in this dispensation, forgiveness is not committed to men. There is one mediator between

God and men, the Apostle Paul says, the man Christ Jesus (I Timothy 2:5). But at that time, under the Kingdom commission, God committed the authority to forgive sins to the disciples. Does this mean they had the power in and of themselves? Of course not. But they did have the authority. This is something we do not have today. God has not entrusted this to men today. But it was a part of the Great Commission.

The Great Commission was Jewish, it was a Kingdom Commission, but it is not our commission today. Upon hearing this, many will ask, "Does this mean you do not believe in missions? Does this mean you do not believe in getting the gospel out?" Of course not. We do believe in a commission, but not the one given to the Twelve. That one has been suspended. God has given us another commission and it is tragically the most neglected commission in all the Scriptures. We have a two-fold commission.

Paul says in I Timothy 2:4 that God **"will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth."** Those are the two things that God wants to accomplish in this Dispensation of the Grace of God. He wants all men to be saved and He wants everyone to come to the knowledge of the truth. What does this entail? In II Corinthians 5:18, 19 we find the ministry of reconciliation. Verse 18 **"And all things are of God, who hath reconciled us to himself by Jesus Christ, and hath given to us the ministry of reconciliation."** What's that? Verse 19 **"To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them; and hath committed unto us the word of reconciliation. Now then we are ambassadors**

for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God. For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him."

The message of reconciliation is simply that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself. When Christ came to this earth, died for our sins, was buried and rose again, He paid the entire price of our sin. In so doing, He reconciled the world. That does not mean that the whole world is saved. It simply means that the world is savable. This is the Divine part. Now our part is to preach the word of reconciliation, which says now you must be reconciled to God. God reconciled the world. That is something we could not do. We could not pay for our own sins. We could not take care of our own sin problem. Now He says to be reconciled to God. How do we do that? By believing in what God has done for us through Christ. The ministry of reconciliation is the first part of our commission.

The second part is in Ephesians 3:9. Once a person is saved, then God wants him/her to understand the fellowship of the mystery. In verse 9, Paul says, **"And to make all men see what is the fellowship of the mystery."** Literally, in the Greek (Majority Text), it is "dispensation of the mystery", **"...which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ."** What is the fellowship or the dispensation of the mystery? It involves the fact that God revealed a new message through the Apostle Paul which had not been revealed to the prophets and had not been told to the Twelve. It was first

committed to Paul. And God wants everyone to know about it. This is part of our job. We are asked why we make such an emphasis of the mystery, of the Grace message committed to the Apostle Paul? It is because it is our job. God has told us to do it. If we are not doing it, we are disobedient children.

Many today have been laboring under the commission given to the Twelve. We might commend them for doing something, yet they have been unfaithful servants if they are not doing what God has told us to do in this Dispensation of Grace. We pray that you will not be an unfaithful servant, but that you will carry out God's commission to us.

15) Do not Peter and Paul teach the same thing?

It is true that in Peter's preaching and Paul's, there are many similarities. For example, they preached the same Christ. Granted Peter preached Christ after His prophetic revelation, Paul after Christ's mystery revelation, which we will see later. They both preached the resurrection. Paul makes this very clear in I Corinthians 15. Peter and the Twelve saw the risen Lord and preached Him as risen. Paul, himself, saw the risen Lord and preached Him as risen. So, yes indeed, Peter and Paul preached many of the same truths that apply in any dispensation. But when it comes to the specific teachings for the people to whom they spoke, there are many differences which we need to understand and we need to proclaim clearly as we rightly divide the word of truth.

We will consider several contrasts to show the difference between the teaching of Peter and Paul. Let us start in

Galatians 2, where we see a contrast in the gospels they preached. It comes to a surprise to many Christians to learn that Peter is not the apostle for this dispensation of Grace. The idea that Peter is the apostle for the church has been ingrained in people for so long and taught traditionally for so long that it is hard for people to grasp that God ordained a new apostle for this dispensation - the Apostle Paul. We want to look at the basic scriptures to show that this is true.

Galatians 2:7 records the Jerusalem council where Paul went up to Jerusalem to discuss with the other apostles the question of circumcision. The conclusion they come to is that the Gentiles do not need to be circumcised to be saved. Neither do they need to be subject to the law of Moses to have a right standing with God. But why is it that some people thought one had to be circumcised to be saved? This goes way back to Abraham when he was given the covenant of circumcision. He was told any male who was not circumcised would be cut off from his people. To be cut off from the people of Israel was a very serious thing. The covenant of God, the promises of God, resided with the people of Israel. To be cut off from the people of Israel was as good as being cut off from the covenants of God. Therefore, it was important for every male to be circumcised to show that they indeed were a part of the people of Israel, therefore a part of the covenant, and that they were exercising faith in the God of Israel. Circumcision was very, very important at that time.

This is why we read in Galatians 2:7, **"But contrariwise, when they saw that the gospel of the uncircumcision was committed unto me, as the gospel of the**

circumcision was unto Peter." Many people wonder whether the Apostle Peter taught circumcision as a part of the gospel? It says right here that he preached "the gospel of the circumcision". Many modern translations have totally obscured the whole point that Paul is making here by translating this "the gospel to the Jews". Of course, Peter preached his gospel to the Jews, but the Holy Spirit, in inspiring Paul's writing used the word "circumcision". This was for a very good reason: Under the Kingdom gospel that Peter preached to the Jews, circumcision was required. This went back to Abraham. It was the gospel of the circumcision. Whereas when Paul was given the mystery, the secret of the gospel of the Grace of God, his message did not include circumcision or any other ritual or religious work whatsoever. Therefore, his message is called "the gospel of the uncircumcision".

This should tell us from the very start that there is a big difference between what Peter was given to preach and what Paul was given to preach. Peter's message included circumcision, and Paul's did not. That is a big, big difference. With this in mind, let us consider the gospel itself.

Peter's gospel message on the day of Pentecost, a Jewish festival, where Jews and proselytes from all over the world were gathered, is recorded in Acts 2:36-38 **"Therefore let all the house of Israel know assuredly, that God hath made that same Jesus, whom ye have crucified, both Lord and Christ. Now when they heard this, they were pricked in their heart, and said unto Peter and to the rest of the apostles, Men and brethren, what shall we do?"** Why are they so

concerned? They had just killed the Messiah and now Christ is alive. And not only is He alive, He is the Lord! They are beginning to tremble! What if you kill a person and the next day he is alive? And he not only is alive but he is the Lord of the universe! You would be shaking in your boots. That is exactly what they are doing. They are saying "what should we do now about this? We are in trouble. We have killed the Messiah. What should we do?" Verse 38**, "Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost."**

Peter tells them they are to do two things - they are to repent and they are to be baptized. We know Paul was given a commission which did not include water baptism, I Corinthians 1:17 **"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel."** But Peter's gospel included water baptism. Many churches are confused over this verse. Some churches teach that if Peter says you have to be baptized for remission of sins, then if you want to be saved, you have got to be baptized. Other churches recognize that Paul teaches that salvation is not by works of righteousness, and not according to our works, but according to God's mercy and grace. They cannot reconcile that Peter is saying you have to baptized and yet Paul says there are no works involved. Therefore, they have to either ignore what Peter says or twist it to say something other than what he really is saying. The way some people do this is to say that what Peter means is to repent and be baptized ***because*** of the remission of sin. The only problem is that is not what God said! The word "for" in "for the remission of sins" literally means "unto the remission of sins". In other words, repentance and

baptism, done in faith, would lead to the remission or forgiveness of sins. Peter preached a gospel which required certain works as evidence of faith. If a person did not do those works, it showed that they did not have faith. That is the gospel of the Kingdom (or "the circumcision").

Did Peter preach the necessity of faith-based works later on? In Acts 10:34 we read, **"Then Peter opened his mouth, and said, Of a truth I perceive that God is no respecter of persons: But in every nation he that feareth him, <u>and worketh righteousness,</u> is accepted with him."** Is Peter still preaching the necessity of some kind of righteous works to be accepted by the Lord? Yes. Works of righteousness. Peter also preaches this in II Peter 1:5-11 where he says, **"...add to your faith..."** and then he lists seven things to do in order to "never fall" and gain "an entrance" into the kingdom.

Do we ever find the Apostle Paul saying things like this? No, Paul never adds any works whatsoever to his gospel for salvation. A notable example is Romans 3:21-28 **"But now..."** Here is one of those dispensational flags. God is telling us that something is changing here. **"But now the righteousness of God without the law is manifested, being witness by the law and the prophets. Even the righteousness of God which is by faith of Jesus Christ..."** This is the faithfulness of Christ, what He did for us at Calvary. He was faithful. That is how this righteousness of God comes. **"...by the faith of Jesus Christ unto all and upon all them that..."** Are baptized? No. Work righteousness? No**. "...<u>that believe</u>: for there is no difference; for all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God; being justified**

freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus." Verse 26 **"To declare, I say, at this time his righteousness: that he might be just, and the justifier of him which believeth in Jesus. Where is boasting then? It is excluded. By what law? of works? Nay: but by the law of faith. Therefore we conclude that a man is justified by faith without the deeds of the law."** This is not what Peter preached, but it is what Paul preached - two different gospels.

Sometimes before people learn to rightly divide the truth, they will think about this and wonder: Peter says you have to do this to be saved, Paul says to do that. Which one should we do? Some people decide to do both. They try it Peter's way and they try it Paul's way, too. Is this how we are going to present the gospel? It had better not be. We had better rightly divide the word of truth and find out who is talking to whom and find out which one is referring to us. Peter writes to the circumcision. He writes to those of the Kingdom program, to the Jews. He writes to those of a different dispensation. We do not preach that one must be baptized to be saved. That is the Kingdom gospel. We preach Paul's gospel for the Gentiles that we are saved by faith alone, in the finished work of Christ. I Corinthians 15:1, **"Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the gospel which I preached unto you, which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand."** Where is our standing before God today? It is in believing the gospel. That is how we have a standing with God. It is not by being baptized, it is not be doing works of righteousness, it is not by keeping the Ten Commandments of the Law. It is by believing the gospel. Paul says**, "For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for**

our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures" (I Corinthians 15:3, 4). Paul says this is the gospel, and we stand in it through faith. Titus 3:5, **"Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost."** This is how we are saved today.

Let us go on to a second contrast between Peter and Paul: How they view the people of God. Let us look at I Peter 2:9 **"But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people; that ye should shew forth the praises of him who hath called you out of darkness into his marvellous light."** A royal priesthood an holy nation. Is Peter talking to members of the Body of Christ? Is he saying we are a holy nation? If we are a nation, what nation are we? Peter is speaking to the Israelites, the godly remnant of Israel in his generation. He gets this right out of Exodus 19 where God promised Israel **"And ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation. These are the words which thou shalt speak unto the children of Israel**" (Exodus 19:6). We, as the Body of Christ, do not make up a nation. The Body of Christ is made up of people of many nations. But Peter is writing to **a** nation here. The nation of Israel.

How does Paul view the people of God? I Corinthians 12:27 says, **"Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular."** This is a great difference. Peter, as he wrote in his generation to that remnant, the godly remnant of Israel, which still existed at that time, wrote to a nation. When Paul writes, he writes to a body,

the Body of Christ, believers of all nations, who have trusted Christ. Some would say, "Does not Peter talk about the Body of Christ, too?" Try to find one reference to the Body of Christ in Peter's writings. There are none. Try to find one reference to the Body of Christ outside of Paul's epistles. There are none. Paul is the only writer to refer to the church which is His body. That is because he is the Apostle of Grace for this dispensation.

A third contrast between Peter and Paul is the nature of their messages. Peter's message was a message of prophecy. It was that which was revealed throughout the times of the prophets. The first passage we want to look at is Acts 3:21. We will then compare Romans 16:25 with that verse. Here are two verses to cross reference to demonstrate the difference between prophecy and mystery. Prophecy and mystery make up the main division of Scripture. Notice the great contrast between these two passages. In Acts 3:19, Peter is preaching to the people of Israel and Judah, **"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord; And he shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you: Whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution of all things, <u>which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began."</u>**

Is Peter talking about the same things the prophets talked about? Yes. He is talking about prophetic revelation. Peter says all the prophets talked about these things. What things? The return of Christ to come back as the King of the earth, to set up a kingdom, to rule over His people Israel, and all of the earth. That is what the

prophets talked about. Read the great prophecies where it says the Lord shall be King over all the earth and His feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives in that day and a Redeemer shall go forth out of Zion (see Zechariah 14:3,4). All of these prophets looked forward to the coming of Christ as King of the earth. Peter spoke to the people of his generation and offered them what the prophets had spoken of through all the ages.

Now consider what Paul preached in Romans 16:25 **"Now to him that is of power to stablish you according to my gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery, <u>which was kept secret since the world began."</u>** Do you see the difference between these two messages. Peter said this message was spoken by all the prophets. Paul says his message was kept secret since the world began. Obviously, they cannot be the same thing. Both of them refer to Jesus Christ, but they refer to Him in a different way. Peter refers to Christ as portrayed by the prophets - the coming King, the Redeemer of Israel, the King of the earth, the Redeemer of Zion. That is the message of prophecy. Paul preaches Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery, that which was not preached by the prophets. Indeed, could not have been because it was hidden, as Paul tells us many times.

The nature of their messages was entirely different. Peter preached prophecy, Paul preached mystery.

A fourth contrast is how Peter and Paul preached faith and salvation. We will compare I Peter 1:9 and Ephesians 1:12, 13. I Peter 1:9 says, **"Receiving the end of your faith, even the salvation of your souls."** What is Peter

talking about? He is simply expressing the same principle that is found back in the gospels under Christ's teaching. Christ said **"he that endures to the end shall be saved"** (Matthew 24:13). Under the Kingdom program, salvation was always portrayed as something out there that they are going towards and it culminated eventually, and will culminate, in the kingdom. Salvation was always portrayed to these kingdom saints as the end of their faith, something out there to receive in the future, a future blessing.

Ephesians 1:12, 13 says, *"***That we should be to the praise of his glory who first trusted in Christ."** Is this the end of your faith or the beginning of your faith*?* **"In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise."** There is a finality to this statement. Ye were sealed! That's it. This comes at the beginning of your faith, at the first moment you believed the gospel. Paul preaches that your faith then ends up sealing your salvation. Peter says, **"receiving the end of your faith, the salvation of your souls."**

A fifth contrast is how both of these apostles refer to Satan. This is both interesting and instructive. Just as God changes the way He deals with men from time to time throughout the dispensations, so the devil, the great imitator of God, changes the way he deals with man, to try and best counteract what God is doing. We see a dispensational aspect to Satan's working when we compare how Peter refers to Satan's work and how Paul refers to Satan's work. I Peter 5:8 **"Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a**

roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour." We recognize Satan is always out to devour whoever he can. But there is a specific application that Peter is drawing, and that is the tribulation period. Peter writes to people who will be living in the tribulation period. It is at that time when Satan is manifested as a terrible beast, as this roaring lion who is going about very openly seeking to devour whomever he may.

How does Paul portray the devil's work in this dispensation? II Corinthians 11:13, 14 **"For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ. And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light."** You might wonder, is Peter right or is Paul? Is Satan operating today as a roaring lion? Or is he operating today as an angel of light? Dispensationally, he is operating today primarily as an angel of light. Satan is trying to come across as very religious. His ministers - Satan's own clergy - are coming across the same way. Verse 15 **"Therefore it is no great thing if his ministers also be transformed as the ministers of righteousness; whose end shall be according to their works."** Why is it important for us to know what to look for? Paul says we are not ignorant of his devices. We have to be aware that Satan may not appear as a roaring lion today, but he surely will appear as an angel of light, as a minister of righteousness. We need to be aware of false teachings which come across in the garb of righteousness.

A sixth contrast is how Peter and Paul present our future hope. Let us look at Peter's offer of the return of Christ to his generation. Acts 3:12 **"And when Peter saw it, he answered unto the people, Ye men of Israel, why**

marvel ye at this?" Verse 13**: "The God of Abraham, and of Isaac, and of Jacob, the God of our fathers, hath glorified his Son Jesus; whom ye delivered up, and denied him in the presence of Pilate, when he was determined to let him go."** Verse 15: **"And killed the Prince of life, whom God hath raised from the dead."** Peter is setting the stage, **"you are the children of the fathers and now you have killed Christ and God raised him up."** Verse 19 **"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord."** What is this talking about? It looks forward to the Kingdom, to the restoration of God's beauty of the earth and the beautiful order of things, the refreshing and the times of restitution. Verse 20 **"And he shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you."** He shall send Jesus Christ. Send Him where? Where is Christ when Peter is speaking? He is in heaven at the right hand of the Father. Where would God send Christ? Back to the earth. And then what would happen? Verse 21 **"...until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began."** Verse 22 **"For Moses truly said unto the fathers, A prophet shall the Lord your God raise up unto you of your brethren, like unto me; him shall ye hear in all things whatsoever he shall say unto you. And it shall come to pass, that every soul, which will not hear that prophet, shall be destroyed from among the people."** Who is this prophet? Remember the Lord predicted back in Moses' day He would raise up a prophet like their brethren - the Lord Jesus Christ Himself. And those who do not hear Him will be destroyed. This looks forward to the end of the tribulation when the enemies of Christ will be wiped out.

Verse 24 **"Yea, and all the prophets from Samuel and those that follow after, as many as have spoken, have likewise foretold of these days. Ye are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant which God made with our fathers, saying unto Abraham, And in thy seed shall all the kindreds of the earth be blessed. Unto you first God, having raised up his Son Jesus, sent him to bless you, in turning away every one of you from his iniquities."** In this passage, Peter offers the return of Christ to the earth, to the people of Israel. We know that they did not receive that offer and therefore, Christ has not yet been sent back. Peter offers to his hearers the Kingdom upon the earth.

What does Paul offer to us? Philippians 3:20 **"For our conversation** [citizenship] **is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Saviour, the Lord Jesus Christ."** When Christ returns for us, how will He return? The Bible says in the air. I Thessalonians 4:16, 17 says, **"For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord."** There is a great difference in how Peter and Paul portray our eternal hope. Peter offers the earthly kingdom, Paul offers the heavenly eternal kingdom.

16) What is this "mystery" that Paul refers to?

We are going to look at five aspects of the mystery. Let us remember the basic definition of the Biblical word for

"mystery". It comes from the Greek word "musterion". What does the word "mystery" actually mean? In the Greek it means "to shut the mouth". That is what a secret is, isn't it? It is when you shut your mouth, do not tell something that you know. This is what God did from before the world began, until He revealed it to Paul. God had something in mind. He had a plan of salvation, a way of redemption for all the people of the earth. But He told no one, He shut the mouth and it stayed secret. When God revealed this secret to Paul, Paul recorded it for us to understand and to enjoy. The first part of the mystery that we want to look at involved the nation of Israel and her condition at this present time. Romans 11:25 **"For I would not, brethren, that ye should be ignorant of this mystery, lest ye should be wise in your own conceits; that blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in."**

If you go back to the prophets, what do you read about Israel? You read that Israel would become a blessing to all of the earth. You read that through Israel's rising the nations would come unto the light of God (see Isaiah 60:1-3). But you never find out what would happen if Israel would fall. Does the Bible predict in the Old Testament that Israel would become blind? Actually, it does. That is not what the mystery is. The fact that Israel would be blinded was predicted by the prophets. But the prophets just sort of leave you hanging. They never tell you how God is going to reach the nations while Israel was blinded. According to the prophetic program, there was no other way. There was no other plan. God's plan, prophetically, was for Israel to be a light to the world. So if you follow the prophets, you are left hanging with sort of a dilemma. Israel will be the blessing to the world, but

now they are blinded. How is God going to reach the Gentiles? This is where the secret comes in. This is where the mystery comes in.

The secret is that this blindness to Israel is only temporary, and while Israel is temporarily blinded God is working a work among the Gentiles. He calls it the fullness of the Gentiles. This is what we are involved in right now as members of the Body of Christ from all nations, including Israel. For you see, under the Mystery program, Israel is no longer singled out as a special and unique nation. Israel was not totally disregarded. Israel has simply become one of the nations and now comes to God the same way anybody comes to God, through faith in Jesus Christ and His finished work on the cross, His death, His burial, and His resurrection for our sins.

This is the first part of the mystery. God has told us what He is going to be doing, and how He is going to do it, to reach the nations while Israel is blinded. The second part of the mystery is perhaps the most important part of all. It has to do with the full meaning of the cross of Christ. Did the Old Testament ever talk about the coming cross of Christ in any way? Yes, it did. Read Psalm 22 where it describes in graphic detail the crucifixion of Christ, even though David did not know Who or what he was really talking about as he recorded the inspiration of the Holy Spirit. It describes the hanging, the thirst, the casting of lots for His garment, everything about Christ's crucifixion relating to the outward details. It is all spelled out. Isaiah also talks about this One Who is going to come and Who is going to be marred beyond recognition and Who is going to be punished for His people. And yet it does not give us some important details. When the prophets speak

of Christ coming and suffering for sin, it is always in the context of suffering for Israel**. "For the sins of my people,"** Isaiah says (Isaiah 53:8).

But you see, God had a secret! He had a secret concerning the rest of the nations. I Corinthians 2:2 says, **"For I determined not to know any thing among you, save Jesus Christ, and him crucified."** This is the gospel message. When Paul came to Corinth, that is what he preached. Verse 6: **"Howbeit we speak wisdom among them that are perfect: yet not the wisdom of this world, nor of the princes of this world, that come to nought."** Paul said of those who do not know the Lord, we just tell them about the cross of Christ. We just preach the gospel to them. But among those who are perfect, we have another message. Who are those who are perfect? Those who are complete in Christ. To these, Paul says, **"But we speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, even the hidden wisdom, which God ordained before the world unto our glory."** (I Corinthians 2:7). Paul says to preach the gospel to the unbelievers and then to those who are saved, those who are perfect, complete in Christ, we preach the mystery.

What is this mystery? Verse 8 **"Which none of the princes of this world knew: for had they known it, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory."** This part of the mystery involves the fact that the death of Christ would be offered to all mankind without distinction and that by simply believing the gospel we can be saved. This is the heart of the mystery. Paul tells us if the princes of this world would have known that, they would never have crucified the Lord of glory. The "princes of this world" includes even the devil. Satan himself did not

know the full extent of what the cross could provide. This explains, at least in part, why God had to keep certain things a secret. This is why He kept that a mystery because according to his plan, Christ had to die. Even the devil, who probably knows the Bible better than any of us, did not know what the cross would do. Why? Because the Old Testament never revealed these things. The prophets did not speak of these things. God did not reveal it at that time. But when Paul came along, God chose him as the vessel through which to reveal it to us.

The third part of the mystery is the Rapture in I Corinthians 15, the great resurrection chapter in which Paul outlines the order of the resurrections. You have first of all, Christ. Notice in verse 23 **"But every man in his own order: Christ the firstfruits."** The Lord Jesus Christ is the first being to ever be truly resurrected. You had people revived from death in the Old Testament, but they died again. They were not fully resurrected to immortality like Christ was. Christ is the firstfruits. And then he says **"afterward they that are Christ's at his coming."** Also read verse 24, **"Then cometh the end, when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God."** Paul is talking about the prophetic saints and their resurrection. If you go back to the Old Testament and read the prophets, do they talk about the resurrection of Christ? Yes, they talk about that many times. David writes **"Thou wilt not leave my soul in hell (Sheol)"** (Psalms 16:10). This statement is applied to Christ in Acts 2:17. Yes, the resurrection of Christ was predicted. Did the Old Testament predict the resurrection of the Old Testament saints? Absolutely. Daniel speaks of a resurrection to everlasting life and a resurrection to shame and everlasting contempt (Daniel 12:2). You do find a

prophetic resurrection of Kingdom saints. Paul speaks of this here. **"They that are Christ's at his coming"** (I Corinthians 15:23).

But has he left anyone out? Is there any other group of people who will be raised some day which the prophets did not know about? The answer is, yes, indeed. Verse 51 says, **"Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed."** This is not the resurrection of Christ, nor of the Old Testament saints. This is the resurrection of the Body of Christ: those who have placed their faith in the finished work of Christ. Did the Old Testament prophets know anything about this? Not a word. They knew nothing of a Rapture. We challenge you to search the Scriptures and see. There are many people who think they can find the Rapture in the Old Testament, but you cannot. It is not there. It was a secret first revealed to Paul.

A fourth aspect of the mystery is in Ephesians 5:31, 32 **"For this cause shall a man leave his father and mother, and shall be joined unto his wife, and they two shall be one flesh. This is a great mystery: but I speak concerning Christ and the church."** What is the relationship between Christ and the church? Christ is the head, the church is the body. That is the point Paul is getting at in his discussion with husbands and wives. There is so much confusion over this point. Many churches and theologians will tell you today that the church is the Bride of Christ. They say this on the basis of Ephesians 5, where it talks about husbands and wives,

and husbands loving their wives as Christ loved the church. But, Paul's point is that Christ is the head of the body and he makes that very clear in verse 23 **"For the husband is the head of the wife, even as Christ is the head of the church: and he is the saviour of the body."** This is the point Paul wants to establish first. Christ is the head, the church is the body. Then he compares a husband and wife to that - not the other way around.

Paul is saying husbands, "I want you to treat your wife the way Christ, the head, treats the body." How does He do that? He loved it, He died for it, He sacrificed for it, He put His all into it. This is the point Paul is getting at. He is not saying the church is the bride. He is saying husbands treat your bride like Christ treats His body. Men, treat your wife like your own body. Have the same care for her that you have for yourself.

The joint union between Jew and Gentile is a fifth part of the mystery, something that was not known to the prophets: that Jew and Gentile would be brought into a union on equal footing. Ephesians 3:3 **"How that by revelation he made known unto me the mystery; (as I wrote afore in few words)."** What is this mystery? Verse 6 **"That the Gentiles should be fellow-heirs, and of the same body and partakers of his promise in Christ by the gospel."** What does Paul mean when he says he spoke about this in a few words? Many times scholars have interpreted that to mean that Paul maybe preached to them verbally or maybe he wrote to them some other time and he is referring to some other thing. Actually, he is referring to what he just wrote in Ephesians. Back in chapter 2:11-13 he said, *"***Wherefore remember, that ye being in time past Gentiles in the**

flesh, who are called Uncircumcision by that which is called the Circumcision in the flesh made by hands. That at that time [under the prophets, under the Old Testament system, under the kingdom program] **ye were without Christ, being aliens from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers from the covenants of promise, having no hope, and without God in the world. But now in Christ Jesus ye who sometimes were far off are made nigh by the blood of Christ. For he is our peace, who hath made both one** [one body in Christ]."

This is what Paul is talking about in Chapter 3 when he says he wrote to them in a few words. This is the mystery: Jew and Gentiles no longer on different planes where the Jew was first and the Gentile followed. Paul says now you are made equal in one body. You are joint heirs together. It is a very beautiful part of the mystery in this dispensation, that Jew and Gentile can be made one.

Once you trust Christ, no matter what your nationality, it suddenly does not matter anymore. When you are a member of the Body of Christ, you may not agree with someone else, but you are not going to have an anger and a hatred towards them. You are going to love them. And it will not matter if the color of his skin is different than yours, or his background or nationality. In Christ, that is all done away with. This is one of the beautiful parts of the mystery.

17) Hasn't there always been Grace?

Theological movements are often labeled according to the thing that they emphasize the most. Those who have felt that speaking in tongues is very important have come to be known as "the Tongues Movement". Those who make

a big emphasis of water baptism are often called "Baptists", and so on. We who recognize that Paul was given a new message known as the Dispensation of the Grace of God are often known as "the Grace Movement". And yet ironically, the fact that we refer to ourselves as Grace believers sometimes offends our denominational friends. They would say "We believe in grace, too. And after all hasn't God always been gracious?" The answer, of course, is yes, God has always been gracious. But the fact remains that He has not always manifested or shown His grace the way that He does today.

We often point to Genesis 6:8 to show there has always been grace as long as God has been around, which has been from everlasting to everlasting. **"But Noah found grace in the eyes of the Lord."** Yet, Noah did not live in the Dispensation of the Grace of God. It is very important that we recognize the difference between the two.

We often use the cliché that there is grace in every dispensation but there is only one dispensation of grace. Even though this is an old saying, it is worthy of repeating, and pondering.

Consider that the Apostle Paul, who is clearly the Apostle of Grace in Scripture, the apostle of the Gentiles, uses the word "grace" more times than all of the other Bible writers combined. Try to visualize what we mean by this: take your Bible, turn to the Epistles of Paul and see how big they are. Then consider that the Old Testament and the epistles by the other writers (the Kingdom writers, the circumcision writers of the Bible), and they do not use the word "grace" in all of their writing as much as Paul uses it in his writings. That should say something, should it not?

It tells us that Paul is truly the Apostle of Grace.

Another interesting fact is to look up the word grace in your concordance. Many times the Old Testament writers used the word grace as people being gracious to one another. Sometimes someone will say to a master in the Old Testament, "If I have found grace in thy sight." This is how the word is often used. Indeed it is used of God, but it is used in a different sense than the way Paul uses it. The grammar of the original text tells us this. The Hebrew word for grace means to stoop down, to condescend, to bring yourself to a lower level. This is exactly how grace is viewed under the Kingdom or the prophetic program. Grace is when God comes down to the level of man. Paul uses it in that way, too, of course - Christ came down and died for our sins), but Paul has another dimension to grace that you simply do not find in the Old Testament nor in any of the Kingdom writings - Peter, James or John. That is the grace that lifts us up! Ephesians 2:4 **"But God, who is rich in mercy, for his great love wherewith he loved us, Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;) and hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus."** This is by the Grace of God.

This shows us one of the major distinctions between the Kingdom program of prophecy and the Body of Christ program of the mystery. In the Kingdom program, God promises an earth, a renewed earth, a new earth, to the meek. **"Blessed are the meek; for they shall inherit the earth"** (Matthew 5:5). And God promises to come down out of heaven to that earth to rule and reign over his people. **"The Lord shall be king over all the earth"**

(Zechariah 14:9). This is the grace that shall be brought unto them (see I Peter 1:10). But Paul reveals that God brings the believer ultimately off of the earth. Today, positionally, He seats us in the heavenlies. Someday literally, He will catch us off of the earth and take us to ever be with the Lord. There is a difference in the Grace of God which is revealed in the Old Testament and in the Kingdom writings and that grace which we know in this Dispensation of Grace.

There are many other ways that the grace of God is illustrated for us. To get a grasp of what Paul is really talking about when he speaks of the Dispensation of the Grace of God, read in Ephesians 3:1 **"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles."** That in itself should arrest our attention. None of the other apostles were ever called apostles of the Gentiles. They were the apostles of the twelve tribes (see Matthew 19:28).

Paul writes in Ephesians 3:2, **"If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward."** What is the dispensation of the grace of God? Many people have stumbled over the word "dispensation" needlessly. Where do you go when you have a medical need and you need some medicine? You go to the "dispensary". What do they do at the dispensary? They dispense, they give something to you. This is all that dispensation means. When God wanted to show His grace in a way that had never been shown before to a greater degree, He dispensed it. He put it in a dispensary. Paul is saying literally that he is the dispenser whom God has chosen to dispense His grace today.

God may have been gracious before, but not the way He is now. What happened under the Law? Hebrews 2:2 **"For if the word spoken by angels was stedfast, and every transgression and disobedience received a just recompence of reward."** That was life under the Law. "Just recompence of reward" means they got punished when they sinned. Punishment was often swift and immediate. But under the dispensation of Grace, many times God allows people to continue in sin with apparently no ill effects. Have you ever pondered why God allows evil men to continue in their evil deeds for so long and lightning does not fall from the sky and burn them up. Why does He allow it? There was a time when that was how God dealt with evil men. That was under the dispensation of the law. We can thank God we live in the dispensation of the grace of God.

18) Does not God heal today?

When we preach the grace message we often point out that the Apostle Paul is a pattern. He says so himself. We often point out that Paul had infirmities of the flesh. We often refer to the fact that we believe that there are certain supernatural gifts and manifestations that God once performed that He does not perform anymore. Many times the subject turns to divine healing. Divine healing is a popular subject today. Many church groups and evangelists proclaim a healing message.

Let us follow the flow of God's dealings throughout the ages. Ever since the fall of man in the Garden of Eden, disease and death have affected the human race. That is implied in that statement that God made to Adam when He said in Genesis 2:17, **"But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it; for**

in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die." The Hebrew text literally reads "dying thou shalt die". In other words, Adam would die spiritually the instant that he ate of the forbidden fruit, separated from God at that moment. But physically, "dying, he would die". He began to die physically that very day. Indeed, we know from natural science that even as a child, our body goes through processes, even as we are growing stronger and healthier, the process of disease and breakdown begins. This is the result of sin.

God made some fantastic promises to His people of Israel, concerning their health. Exodus 15:26 is one of many references showing God's promise to the nation of Israel. **"And said, if thou wilt diligently hearken to the voice of the Lord thy God, and wilt do that which is right in his sight, and wilt give ear to his commandments, and keep all his statutes, I will put none of these diseases upon thee, which I have brought upon the Egyptians: for I am the Lord that healeth thee."** God's promise to Israel was: IF you obey my covenant, my commandment, you will not have diseases. That was an amazing promise in a world where God told Adam if he ate of the forbidden fruit, "dying you shall die". Now He tells the Israelites "you are not going to have these diseases if you obey My commandments."

Many people as they study the Scriptures, fail to rightly divide the word of truth. They read this and even though it is addressed to the nation of Israel and not to the Body of Christ, they fail to take this into account. They say it says IF **<u>we</u>** obey we will not have diseases. And bless their hearts, many of them have more faith than we do. They are clinging to the promise that says you will not

have any diseases.

What happened throughout Israel's history? There were times when they were fairly obedient and things seemed to be going very well. But of course, there were also times they failed and indeed they got sick and many died.

What is God's promise to us today? There was a great change that took place in God's healing program. While the nation of Israel was in God's favor as a nation, He continued to give the gift of healing to His servants. When the Lord Jesus Christ was on the earth, He ministered healing to the Israelites in accordance with God's promise. When the Apostles went forth, they were given the gift of healing to illustrate the perfection of the Kingdom when God will remove disease and the only time when people will die during the Millennial Kingdom is when they have definitely committed a sin. They were given the ability to heal diseases and even to raise people from the dead. Paul himself was able to perform gifts of healing by the power of the Holy Spirit. One notable case is in Acts 28:7-10, **"In the same quarters were possessions of the chief man of the island, whose name was Publius; who received us, and lodged us three days courteously. And it came to pass, that the father of Publius lay sick of a fever and of a bloody flux: to whom Paul entered in, and prayed, and laid his hands on him, and healed him. So when this was done, others also, which had diseases in the island, came, and were healed: Who also honoured us with many honours."** Here Paul was able to perform, through the power of God, miraculous healings at will and immediately. Physical healings were instantaneous.

Acts 28 is important because it brings to the end a time of transition when God's nation of Israel was being put aside and the Body of Christ was brought into being through the ministry of Paul. Paul called the Jews together who could not agree on some things in Acts 28:25-27 **"And when they agreed not among themselves, they departed, after that Paul had spoken one word, Well spake the Holy Ghost by Esaias the prophet unto our fathers, Saying, Go unto this people, and say, Hearing ye shall hear, and shall not understand; and seeing ye shall see, and not perceive: For the heart of this people is waxed gross, and their ears are dull of hearing, and their eyes have they closed; lest they should see with their yes, and hear with their ears, and understand with their heart, and should be converted, and I should heal them."** God promised Israel healing, spiritual and physical. But now Paul is saying what Isaiah said is true, you did not understand, you did not perceive and therefore, God is going to send you away and send His salvation to the Gentiles, verse 28 **"Be it known therefore unto you, that the salvation of God is sent unto the Gentiles, and that they will hear it."**

What does this have to do with divine healing? Shortly before this time Paul was able to heal. But notice what happens one or two years later. Paul has just arrived at Rome in Acts 28 and in II Timothy 4:20, Paul is writing as a prisoner in Rome, **"Erastus abode at Corinth: but Trophimus have I left at Miletum sick."** We might ask why if just a few years before Paul was able to heal those who were sick, why do we read now "I've left Trophimus at Miletum sick"? Some people say because Paul was in prison and could not go and heal him. That is no excuse, for you read in the book of Acts that Paul was even able

to take a napkin or a handkerchief he had touched, and when it got to the person and touched them, they were healed! If Paul really wanted to bring healing or if he was still able to, he could have done it even from prison.

Also, I Timothy 5:23 says, **"Drink no longer water, but use a little wine for thy stomach's sake and thine often infirmities."** Again we might ask why does not Paul just heal him? Timothy would be able to minister better if he was not sick, wouldn't he? Yet Paul prescribes a primitive and probably effective medicinal remedy rather than healing him. What has changed from a couple of years before to when he writes I & II Timothy? The nation of Israel has been completely put out of the picture. God is no longer fulfilling to them that promise that if you obey Him He will heal them. A very great change has taken place, has it not?

But cannot God still heal today? Yes, of course. God is still God. He can do whatever He wants. But the fact is, God operates according to His word. He works with us according to how He has revealed Himself to us. And in this dispensation, while God still can heal, it is the exception rather than the rule. Let us look at Paul's example in I Timothy 1:16. Paul said he is the pattern to those who should believe hereafter. II Corinthians 12:7 says, **"And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure. For this thing I besought the Lord thrice, that it might depart from me."** Here we find Paul, the one who could heal, unable to find healing himself. And notice the Lord's answer in verse 9 **"And he said unto**

me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me." Then Paul responds in verse 10, **"Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses for Christ's sake: for when I am weak, then am I strong."** God's order for today is that under normal circumstances he allows us to be ill from time to time.

Does this mean God could not heal us if He wanted to? No, He could heal us if that were His purpose. But He often has a higher purpose and it simply illustrates how God is dealing in this dispensation. He is not dealing so much with the outer man as the inner man. Paul says the outer man perishes but the inner man is renewed day by day (see II Corinthians 4:16). This illustrates the difference between the Kingdom program and this present evil age. In the Kingdom, there will be people who live for 1,000 years. If they get sick, according to James (writing to the twelve tribes) they are to call for the elders, and they will lay hands on them and anoint them with oil and pray for them and they will be healed. If you never got sick or if you got sick and you always were healed, you would never die! And that is exactly what will happen during the Millennial Kingdom, one thousand years of righteous ruling and reigning by the Lord. There will be people who have that healing ministry, but today Paul says we live in a present evil age. The outer man is perishing, we groan within ourselves waiting for the adoption to wit the redemption of our bodies (see Romans 8:23).

Does that mean we have to be down in the dumps? Does

that mean we have to walk around with our jaw a mile long and grumbling? Paul says, "when I am weak then I am strong". What Paul means is that when we have weaknesses and we still accomplish something for the Lord, then we can point to Him and we can say He did it through us. We had nothing to do with it. Isn't that where the Lord wants us all? By the grace of God many times He does allow us to have relatively good health. We should be careful with what we eat and activities we're involved in, etc. We should not tempt the Lord. The Lord is often very gracious, but when He allows us illness, He does it for a purpose in this dispensation of grace.

It is amazing that even when presented with solid Biblical evidence some people are still hesitant to embrace the truth, sometimes even when they cannot raise any arguments against the truth. If this proves anything, it proves what a strong grip tradition has on the hearts and minds of men. We have been considering some of the most common questions about the Grace message. The last two questions are often asked by those who cannot really dispute the facts of the Grace message, but they still have some reservations. They are a bit apprehensive about how non-traditional it seems to sound. Let us remind you of some of the words of the Lord Jesus Christ and of the Apostle Paul. In Matthew 15:1 the Lord was approached by Pharisees and it says "**Then came to Jesus scribes and Pharisees, which were of Jerusalem, saying, Why do thy disciples transgress the tradition of the elders? for they wash not their hands when they eat bread. But he answered and said unto them, Why do ye also transgress the commandment of God by your tradition?"** Verse 6 says **"And honour not his**

father or his mother, he shall be free. Thus have ye made the commandment of God of none effect by your tradition." Mark it down, if you are faithful to the Lord, you will have to violate someone's tradition.

But the important question is, whose traditions are you going to violate? Man's traditions or God's teachings? What an important question! The Apostle Paul utters a similar warning to us in Colossians 2:8. The Apostle very clearly and without pulling any punches says these important words, **"Beware lest any man spoil you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, after the rudiments of the world, and not after Christ."** Yes, the Grace message often sounds nontraditional to many people. But God has warned us, has He not, time and time again, to beware of the traditions of men. Do not let tradition keep you from the truth. Search the Scriptures and see whether these things be so. This is all God asks of you. Search the Scriptures.

19) What difference does all of this make? All Christians are going to be in heaven anyway, aren't they?

Yes and no. Not all those who call themselves Christians will be in heaven, for you can call yourself anything you want. This does not mean you are one. You might call yourself a brain surgeon, but don't expect anyone to come to you when they are in need of a brain surgeon, unless you really are one. There are tragically many people who call themselves Christians. Surveys report that as many as 50-60% of the population in our country that call themselves Christians, but calling yourself one does not make you one. Yes, all true Christians will be in heaven.

Praise the Lord! All those who have truly placed their faith in Christ in His finished work on the cross, His death, burial and resurrection; those who simply believe that pure and simple gospel message will be in heaven. Tragically, however, millions of church goers who sit in services all over the land or all over the world will never hear the gospel.

One of our members was invited to a nursing home Bible study. She thought she would go and as someone came to help her from her room to the meeting room, she said, "Oh wait! Let me get my Bible!" And their answer was, "You're not going to need that. They don't use the Bible." Why, pray tell, do they call it a Bible study then? Yet this tragically illustrates what happens in many churches. A pastor once shared how he went to preach at a certain denominational church and he asked someone to read the Scripture before he preached. They said, "Oh, ummm... I know we have a Bible around here somewhere." How many people sit thinking they are hearing God's word when in fact, they're just getting a warmed over Reader's Digest article.

Just as tragically or perhaps even more tragically, millions more will hear a corrupted or an incorrect gospel which will not save them at all. They will think they are saved, but they really are not. And finally, there will be those who will hear little snatches of the true gospel here and there, but then they will be told that they have to do some work in order to be saved! "Pray this combination of words and you'll be saved. Or come forward and kneel at the front and then you'll be saved."

So what is the true gospel? It is the Gospel of the Grace

of God which was first revealed to the Apostle Paul. We want to point out two things about salvation. First, our faith must be in the right gospel, in the correct message. Secondly, this faith must be exercised entirely free of works.

Here is the gospel in a nut shell, the simplest elements, the basic parts of the gospel message. The word gospel just means good news. A good message! The best message you will ever hear. Paul says in I Corinthians 15:1-4 **"Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the gospel which I preached unto you."** We know we are going to get it straight from the Apostle of the Gentiles. Why does he have to identify it as the one he preached unto them? It is because others were preaching other gospels. There were the Twelve Apostles who were preaching another gospel. It was true, but it was the gospel of the Kingdom. There were others who were preaching mixed gospels that contained perhaps an element of grace but also an element of the Kingdom message; some requirement of baptism or something else from the Kingdom program. And so Paul says, here is the one I preached to you. And he says **"which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand."**

When Paul says "in which ye stand", it is at that point that we are saved. He is saying, "Here is your standing in Christ through the gospel which I preached to you." And then in verse 2 he says **"By which also ye are saved <u>if..."</u>** This has troubled a lot of people - "why have an 'if' all of a sudden? I thought there weren't any ifs, ands, or buts. I thought it was believe this and you're saved." That is true. When you believe the gospel, you are saved. Why does he say "if"? It is because in verse 2, Paul has turned

his attention from our position in Christ to the practical application of spiritual truth. In verse 2, Paul is moving on and saying "you are saved, you are preserved, you are kept in a mental, physical way by continuing to keep in memory what I preached unto you." Paul is moving from verse 1 - our position, our salvation in Christ - to verse 2 - our practice of the Christian life. The point he is making is not only are you saved and have a standing in Christ by believing the gospel, but it will also enable you to continue to live the Christian life.

Why does he bring this up when speaking to the Corinthians? The Corinthians were one of the most carnal groups of believers. Throughout the book, Paul is telling them how they can live salvation out in a practical way. Part of it is keeping in mind the things Paul had preached unto them. That is why he says, "unless you have believed in vain" because they had allowed a false doctrine to really get them off the track. That was the belief that there was no resurrection. In verse 17 he explains further what he means. **"And if Christ be not raised, your faith is vain; ye are yet in your sins."** It is important to believe in the resurrection, isn't it? It is important for our salvation because it is part of the gospel, but it is also important for our daily life, because if you believe the false doctrine that there is no resurrection, then you are going to come up with such foolish ideas as: 'Let's just eat and drink for tomorrow we die. Let's not worry about what's going to happen hereafter, because we're not going to be raised anyway.' And that is in fact, what some of these Corinthians were doing. So Paul is being doctrinal, but also very practical.

He gets back to the gospel in verse 3. In verse 1, he said

*"***I declare unto you the gospel which I preached unto you"** and now he gets to it in verse *3* **"For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures."** The death, burial and resurrection of Christ is the summary of the gospel - the good news. When we believe it, we are saved. Countless people have questioned the need of the simplicity of just believing the gospel. Many say it cannot be that easy! Do you know what our answer is? It was not easy for God. It was not easy to send His only Son to come down as an innocent person and bear the sins of the world. That was not easy. That was the hardest thing God ever did. But it is easy for us because it was hard for Him. And now we can offer a simple gospel. Believe the gospel.

Not only must we understand the right gospel, we must exercise faith alone without works. In Romans 4:5, we have the answer to the confusion that exists today on what must we do to be saved. We have often had people who sat under our ministry for some time and have come later and said it was when we went through Romans 4:5 that it finally came together and it finally clicked that we just believe with no works attached for our salvation. Starting in verse 4: **"Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt."** When you work for something and get paid for it, that's not grace, that is what is owed to you. And that is what Paul is establishing here. He is saying if you are going to call your salvation grace, you cannot have a works system because then it would not be grace anymore. Verse 5 **"But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the**

ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness." That's grace! If you did not work, but you still got paid, that would be a gift. That's grace! Paul says that is how you are justified. **"His faith is counted for righteousness."**

This is the answer to many who will say, "Oh, I've believed for years, that Christ died for my sins and was buried and rose again. I was raised with that. I heard that in church week after week." But as long as they are adding one ounce, one iota, as long as they were adding anything to their faith for their salvation, that is not what God has asked. It is by grace, through faith, without works.

Will all who call themselves Christians be in heaven? Sadly, no. Will all who have believed the gospel be in heaven? Praise the Lord, yes. That is why it is good news.

Going right along with this question, many ask, shouldn't we do good works? Aren't we supposed to do good works? Of course we should! Many get the idea that we are emphasizing grace and no works, therefore we should not do any good works. Just put up our feet, take it easy, and do what we want, do what we please. Is that what God intended? Of course not. In fact, the reason God saved us is so we COULD do good works.

Ephesians 2:8-10 says, **"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God; Not of works, lest any man should boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them."** Don't get the cart before the

horse. We are His workmanship. This is a very beautiful word in the Greek - "poiema" - which means poem. We are God's poem, a beautiful creation. He uses this word one more time in Romans 1:20 when He is talking about the fact that we are without excuse because of the creation and there the word "poiema" is translated "the things which are made". Indeed, that describes what God has done with us. He says we are created in Christ Jesus. We were brought into being in a physical sense when we were conceived and then we grow into maturity. But we are created anew when we are saved. That is why Paul says **"if any man is in Christ, he is a new creation"** (II Corinthians 5:17).

Did you realize God works a new creative act in your life when you are saved? You are a new creation. You are His poem, His workmanship. IT IS NOT UNTIL GOD MAKES US ANEW THAT WE ARE ABLE TO DO GOOD WORKS. Any so-called good works that we do before salvation**,** are filthy rags in God's eyes. That is one of the tragedies that exists today in many people's lives. They think they are doing good works, when in fact, their works are as filthy rags (see Isaiah 64:6). Our good works AFTER salvation are a part of God's foreordained plan for believers.

Step One: Get saved by believing the gospel. Step Two: Do good works by the grace of God.

We see this truth emphasized in no uncertain terms in Titus**.** Titus was a pastor at Crete. Crete had a reputation for being a bit slovenly, evil, and as Paul says in Chapter 1:12, "**liars, evil beasts, slow bellies"** (or lazy gluttons), and to these Paul instructs Titus to teach. Notice in Titus

2:14 **"Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of good works."** Titus 3:8, **"This is a faithful saying, and these things I will that thou affirm constantly, that they which have believed in God might be careful to maintain good works. These things are good and profitable unto men."** Here are instructions to the teacher, Paul says to Titus, affirm these things constantly. It sounds like a broken record type of preaching, doesn't it? Why does he have to say that? The Lord knows our tendency to slack off when it comes to the area of good works. He knows that we need continual reminding that we are to do good works as believers. Again, Paul is very clear that we are not talking about our salvation. We are talking about what we do after we are saved. "Constantly affirm these things," Paul says.

What does it mean to do good works? Someone has illustrated it like this: Let us say that across the street from you there lives an elderly couple and one day their adult son, who is very wealthy, comes to your house. He is visiting from another state and he says to you, "Mom and Dad are getting up in years. They are still able to live alone, but it is getting harder for them and I would like to make an offer to you. I would like you to just keep your eye on them. Just watch out for them. If you notice that Dad's having a little hard time with the mower, go help him start it. Maybe mow the lawn for him once in awhile through the summer. And in the winter time, they still drive, but when the snow gets a little deep, maybe just watch and blow the driveway out and scoop the walk. I am not asking you to do this full-time. I am not asking you to quit your job. I just want you to watch out for them. Maybe just stop in and say hi once in awhile. And

if you will do this, I am prepared to pay you $50,000 a year."

Isn't this what God is asking of us? Just be the kind of Christian that we should be. I will reward you, God says. I will reward you in My time. Would you be a good person like that for $50,000 a year? Would you give it a try? Would you be that kind of a person for the Lord?

Can we do good works just out of the goodness of our heart because it is a heart that has been renewed by the Holy Spirit? Can we do good, can we just share a good word with people, share the gospel with people, help out here and there? Can we just be the kind of testimony that God really wants us to be? Just because we know the Lord? This is part of what Paul has in mind. Let us constantly affirm these things.

20) If all of this is true why don't more churches teach it?

The answer to this question is one of the saddest stories of human history. The devil hates the mystery which was revealed to Paul. He hates it with a passion. Why? Because first, it offers salvation to all mankind freely through simple faith in the gospel. What more could God have done? How much easier could He have made it? The grace message tells people this marvelous truth. Secondly, the reason Satan hates it is that it places the believer in the very position that Satan wanted for himself. He wanted to be in the heavenlies and to be a ruler in the heavenlies. By the grace of God, this is what God is offering members of the Body of Christ. Those who suffer with Him will reign with Him! (see II Timothy 2:12)

Therefore, when God revealed this message to Paul, Satan immediately began fighting it. Let us give some examples of this. In I Thessalonians 2:16-18, Paul, referring to the Jews of his day, the unbelieving Jews, he says **"Forbidding us to speak to the Gentiles that they might be saved, to fill up their sins alway: for the wrath is come upon them to the uttermost. But we, brethren, being taken from you for a short time in presence, not in heart, endeavoured the more abundantly to see your face with great desire. Wherefore, we would have come unto you, even I Paul, once and again; but Satan hindered us."**

You see, Satan knew Paul had the message for today, so he tried to hinder him. Tragically, the people of Paul's own day began turning from the message he preached, even while he was still alive. It would be one thing if this message was taught by the Apostle Paul but somewhere along the line, people just stopped believing it. But you see, it is another thing when we can turn right to the pages of Scripture and find when this began to happen! This is revealed in II Timothy 1:15 **"This thou knowest, that all they which are in Asia be turned away from me."** You might say, so what? There weren't that many believers in Asia anyway, were there? There were when Paul was there. There were churches galore. There were many believers - grace believers - in Asia. And yet, Paul sadly has to write at the end of his life, "all they in Asia have turned away from me".

What is Paul referring to? Is it that they just didn't want to stand with him as he was held prisoner? That may be part of it, but there is more to it than that. What has Paul

just talked about in the context? Notice, in verses 11-13, **"Whereunto I am appointed a preacher, and an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles. For the which cause I also suffer these things: nevertheless I am not ashamed: for I know whom I have believed, and am persuaded that he is able to keep that which I have committed unto him** (Literally, in the Greek "that which was committed unto me".) **against that day. Hold fast the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me."** Paul says to Timothy, the things I have taught you, the sound words you heard from me, hold fast to them. All those in Asia have turned away. He is talking about the Gospel of Grace.

II Timothy 4:10 **"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world, and is departed unto Thessalonica; Crescens to Galatia, Titus unto Dalmatia. Demas hath forsaken me, all they in Asia have turned away from me**." Thankfully, by the grace of God, the distinctiveness of the Pauline message has been recovered and with God's help we are responsible to spread this message and to teach it to our children, that it be not lost again. This is why we must continue to emphasize God's way of studying the Bible, II Timothy 2:15 **"Rightly dividing the word of truth".**

Several years ago we had a visitor at church for two or three weeks, and when stopping at their home for a visit and the husband said, "We've been visiting for a few weeks at your church, and I've noticed that every week you talk about rightly dividing the word of truth. Is that some kind of a theme for this year or something?" We replied, "No, that's our theme until the Lord returns!" He evidently was somewhat offended that we would

emphasize the very key to studying the Scriptures as recorded in II Timothy 2:15. That's tragic, and sad. By the grace of God we must continue on to rightly divide the word of truth and stand for the Gospel of the Grace of God.

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